

Novel Export

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CHAPTER 1 — The Wrong Seat

The library was almost empty at 7 PM. That was the reason Kiran liked it. Not for the books — he could read anywhere — but for the specific silence that settled between those shelves after dinner, when most students were back in their hostels eating Maggi and watching reels. He could just be.

In that quiet, Kiran could exist without performing.

He had a system. Third row from the back. Left side. Second chair from the window. The evening light came in at exactly the right angle for an hour before the tube lights buzzed to life. He had sat in that same seat for eleven months. Since the first week of second year, when he'd wandered in looking for an escape from his noisy roommate and found, instead, something that felt like peace.

He did not expect anyone to be sitting in it.

And yet.

There was a person in his seat — sprawled in it, actually, one arm hooked over the backrest, reading something with the relaxed ease of someone who had never had to try hard at anything. Dark hair slightly messy, jaw sharp, wearing a plain white shirt with the sleeves pushed to the elbows. He hadn't even brought a bag. Just a single notebook, lying open, half the page blank.

Kiran stood at the edge of the row.

He considered leaving. Finding another seat. The library was not that empty — there were other chairs, other windows. He was not obligated to confront a stranger over furniture.

But he had a half-finished assignment due at 9 AM and his room was a disaster and the hostel common room smelled like someone had fried fish in it again, and this was his seat, and so Kiran cleared his throat.

The person looked up.

He had the kind of face that made people pause. Not aggressively handsome — not movie-poster handsome — but something quieter and more dangerous: the kind of face that looked better the longer you looked at it. Like the first glance never quite captured it fully.

"Yeah?" he said. No apology in his tone. Just a question.

"That's—" Kiran stopped. That's my seat sounded unhinged out loud. "I usually sit here."

The guy looked at the chair, then back at Kiran. He seemed to consider this for a moment. Then, instead of moving, he tilted his head at the empty chair beside him.

"Sit there," he said, like it was obvious. Like it was a solution.

Kiran wanted to say something. He wasn't sure what. Instead, he sat down in the adjacent chair, placed his bag on the table, opened his laptop, and tried very hard to focus on fluid mechanics.

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Forty minutes passed. The tube lights buzzed on. The library stayed quiet.

The person — the intruder — had fallen asleep somewhere in the middle of that silence, cheek resting on his folded arm, notebook untouched. His breathing was slow and even. He looked younger when he slept.

Less like someone who took up space on purpose and more like someone who had simply gotten tired.

Kiran looked at him for exactly four seconds, told himself that was enough, and went back to his assignment.

He didn't ask his name that night.

He didn't need to. The name was just a fact — something that would arrive eventually the way things did in a hostel campus, through the noise of other people's conversations, through the way the world kept insisting on bringing certain people to your attention.

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Two days later, during the Operating Systems lecture, Kiran heard someone two rows ahead laugh at something, loud and real and completely unbothered by the professor's presence. He looked up without meaning to.

Oh, he thought. It's him.

His name, Kiran learned from the friend beside him who whispered it like a piece of campus trivia, was Arjun Mehta. Third year. Mechanical. Known for two things: being the sort of person everyone wanted to be around, and the sort of person who made everything look effortless.

Kiran filed this information away and told himself it was irrelevant.

He was very wrong about that.

CHAPTER 2 — Overlap

They kept running into each other the way things do when the universe has decided something without consulting you.

The canteen. The morning batch — 8:15 AM, when the idli was still hot and the sambar hadn't turned sour. Kiran always took the corner table. Arjun, apparently, always took the table beside it. Kiran noticed this on a Tuesday. By Thursday, he had confirmed it was a pattern. By the following week, he had stopped being surprised by it.

They didn't talk. There was no reason to talk. They were not in the same department, not in the same circle, not in the same universe of social relevance. Arjun was the kind of person who arrived somewhere and the room reorganized itself around him — friends materializing, laughter following, conversations building without effort.

Kiran was the kind of person who arrived somewhere and quietly found a corner.

But corners and centers of rooms exist in the same space, and sometimes the geometry of a canteen meant that Arjun's laughter reached Kiran's corner clearly enough to be distracting.

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The lab partner arrangement was not something either of them planned.

It was the Applied Physics lab, which both departments shared because the college had exactly one working spectrometer and the administration had long since stopped pretending otherwise. The instructor read names from a list. Kiran heard his own name. He heard the name after it.

Arjun Mehta.

Arjun found him before Kiran could process what to do about this information. He dropped into the empty stool beside Kiran and placed his notebook on the bench with the same easy carelessness he seemed to bring to all furniture he encountered.

"Hey," he said. "Library guy."

Kiran looked at him. "You remember that?"

Arjun shrugged. "You looked at me like I'd committed a crime." He said it without any malice. Like it was just an observation. "Arjun."

"Kiran."

"Right." Arjun looked at the spectrometer in front of them with the expression of someone who had already decided it was someone else's problem. "Do you know how this works?"

"Yes."

"Perfect," Arjun said, and smiled — not the performative version Kiran had seen him deploy across

the canteen, but something smaller, more direct. "I'll handle the writing. You explain it to me while I write. It'll be efficient."

It was, somehow, efficient. And that was the problem.

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Because efficiency implied a system, and a system implied repetition, and by the third lab session Kiran had begun to understand something uncomfortable: he was not indifferent to Arjun. He had been telling himself he was, but indifference didn't explain the way he noticed when Arjun was five minutes late, or the way his attention kept drifting during calculations to the sound of Arjun's pen against paper.

This was not love. Kiran was careful to be clear with himself about that. He had read enough to know the difference between love and the gravitational pull of a person who happened to be compelling. This was the second thing. This was ordinary.

He repeated this to himself on the walk back to the hostel that evening, hands in his pockets, the Hyderabad sky going amber at the edges.

He almost believed it.

CHAPTER 3 — Maggi at Midnight

The power cut happened at 11:47 PM on a Wednesday. Kiran knew the exact time because he'd been watching the clock on his laptop, calculating how many more minutes he could stay awake before his 7 AM class became a genuine health risk. And then the screen went dark, the fan slowed, and the hostel corridor outside his door became completely silent in the specific way it only did when everyone's fans stopped simultaneously.

He sat in the dark for a moment. Then he got up, found his phone, and went to the corridor.

Half the wing was already there. This was the thing about power cuts — they were social events, forcing people out of their separate lives and into the same shared darkness. Someone had produced a candle from somewhere. Someone else had a portable speaker. The general mood was of unexpected relief, like a collective exhale.

Arjun was sitting on the floor against the corridor wall, back straight, legs stretched out, talking to someone Kiran didn't recognize. He looked up when Kiran came out, and did the thing Kiran had started to anticipate and dread in equal measure: he made eye contact like it was nothing, and gestured at the floor beside him.

"Sit," he said. "We're doing hostel midnight survival."

Kiran sat. He wasn't sure when he'd started defaulting to whatever Arjun suggested in these situations, but here he was.

Maggi arrived eventually — someone had a gas cylinder and a pot, the kind of contraband hostel living turned into necessity. It was passed around in whatever containers were available: lids, cups, one person inexplicably had a small bowl. Kiran ended up with a mug. Arjun ate directly from the pot lid, completely unbothered.

They sat in the candle-lit corridor, a group of eight or ten, eating Masala Maggi at midnight, and something happened that Kiran hadn't expected.

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Arjun talked to him. Not at him, not around him — to him. Asked him things: where he was from, what he did when he wasn't studying (implying, somehow, that he'd noticed Kiran was usually studying). He listened to the answers with the kind of attention that felt rare — not politely waiting for his turn to speak, but actually there, following the thread.

"You don't say much," Arjun said at some point. Not as criticism. More like something he'd noticed and found interesting.

"I say enough," Kiran said.

Arjun considered this. "Fair," he said. And then: "What are you thinking about right now?"

No one had ever asked Kiran that. Not like that — direct, genuinely curious, with no expectation of

a particular answer.

"I was thinking," Kiran said slowly, "that I don't know how power cuts can feel like a relief when they're objectively inconvenient."

Arjun was quiet for a moment. The candle flickered between them.

"Because they take the decision away," Arjun said. "You don't have to choose to stop. The stopping just happens."

Kiran looked at him.

There was something underneath that observation. Something that didn't fit the easy confidence, the social fluency. Something that knew about the exhaustion of always having to choose.

He didn't follow that thread. He wasn't ready to, yet.

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The power came back at 1:15 AM. Everyone dispersed. Arjun said goodnight in that casual way he had — easy, unhurried, like goodnight was just another word and not a small ending.

Back in his room, fan running again, Kiran lay on his bed and stared at the ceiling.

He thought about Arjun's answer.

Because they take the decision away.

He thought about it for a long time.

CHAPTER 4 — Rain

The rain came without warning in the second week of August. Not the usual Hyderabad drizzle — the kind that lasted four minutes and left the roads smelling like petrichor and diesel. This was a real rain, sky-opening, filling the gutters, bouncing off the hostel rooftop in a continuous roar. It started at 4 PM and by 5 it was clear it wasn't stopping.

Kiran had made the miscalculation of going to the library after his last lecture. Now he was standing at the entrance, looking at the quad that separated him from his hostel, which had become a minor river.

He had no umbrella. He was carrying his laptop.

He was calculating the probability of making it across without catastrophe when someone appeared beside him. Arjun.

He was eating something — a packet of biscuits, apparently acquired from the library's illicit snack system — and looking at the rain with an expression of uncomplicated delight.

"It's bad," Kiran said.

"It's great," Arjun said.

"My laptop—"

"Put it in your bag and hug the bag to your chest. Come on."

"Arjun—"

But Arjun had already stepped out into the rain.

He turned back after three steps, completely drenched within seconds, and looked at Kiran with an expression that was not quite a dare and not quite an invitation but something in between that Kiran found impossible to refuse.

He stepped out.

The rain was cold and immediate and total. It soaked through his shirt in about four seconds. He hugged his bag to his chest and ran, following Arjun across the quad, and somewhere in the middle of it — waterlogged, half-blind, doing something completely impractical — he started laughing.

*somewhere in the middle of it — waterlogged, half-blind, doing something completely impractical
— he started laughing.*

He wasn't sure when it started. Only that it was already happening when he noticed it. And Arjun was laughing too, shouting something over the noise of the rain that Kiran couldn't hear, reaching back and grabbing Kiran's wrist to pull him in the right direction because apparently Kiran had veered off course.

The touch lasted maybe three seconds.

Arjun let go.

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They made it to the hostel overhang and stood there dripping, breathing hard from the run.

"You're crazy," Kiran said. He was still smiling. He couldn't stop.

"Yeah," Arjun said. He pushed wet hair off his forehead and looked at Kiran with an expression Kiran hadn't seen on him before. Something slightly softer. Slightly less performed. "But you laughed."

Something slightly softer. Slightly less performed.

"I laugh."

"Not usually." Arjun said it simply. Then he looked out at the rain for a moment. "You should do it more."

Kiran didn't know what to say to that. He stood there dripping on the hostel step, bag still clutched to his chest, and felt something settle in him that he didn't have a name for yet.

You should do it more.

- * -

He turned it over that night while doing laundry. While eating dinner. While trying to read.

He was not falling in love, he told himself.

He was just not not falling in love. Which was different.

He was just not not falling in love. Which was different.

CHAPTER 5 — Watching

The college fest happened in October, three days of stages and stalls and the loosening of all campus formality.

Kiran went because Priya dragged him. Priya was his closest friend in the department — small, relentless, constitutionally incapable of accepting "I'd rather stay in" as a valid answer. She wanted to see the dance competition. Kiran wanted to finish a book. Priya won.

The amphitheater was packed. Kiran found a spot toward the back, which was good — he could leave if necessary, he could exist without the press of the crowd becoming overwhelming. Priya immediately disappeared into the crowd toward friends she'd spotted. He stayed where he was, watching the stage.

The dance performance from the Mechanical department came third.

Kiran told himself later that it was just proximity. That he was already watching the stage, that it wasn't specific, that anyone in his line of sight would have drawn the same quality of attention.

But he watched Arjun.

It wasn't that Arjun was the best dancer on stage. He was good — easy, rhythmically confident, taking up space without apology the way he seemed to do everywhere. But there were others on stage who were more technically precise.

What Kiran couldn't look away from was something harder to name. The way Arjun moved like he'd stopped thinking about being watched. The way the performance seemed to happen because it was genuinely happening for him, not for the audience. There was something unguarded in it. Something Kiran recognized as rare.

And then Arjun looked up, mid-performance, scanning the crowd in the casual way people do — and stopped.

Found Kiran.

It lasted two seconds. Maybe three. Arjun didn't smile, didn't wave. Just a moment of eye contact across the distance of a crowd. And then the performance pulled him back and it was over.

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But the two seconds stayed.

Kiran stood in the back of the amphitheater and felt, with absolute clarity, the specific vertigo of the moment you realize something you've been trying not to realize.

This is not a phase, he thought. This is not proximity. This is not gravity.

He stayed for the rest of the performance. He clapped with everyone else.

Afterward, he walked back to his hostel alone, taking the long way around, through the back road behind the canteen where no one went in the evening. He needed the extra minutes.

He had known, in the abstract, for a while. But knowing abstractly and knowing concretely were two different things, and what had just happened in the amphitheater was concrete. It had weight.

He liked Arjun.

He let himself say it, alone on a dark path in October, with the sounds of the fest carrying faintly from the distance.

I like Arjun.

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Then he kept walking. Because what else was there to do? Arjun had never indicated anything. The eye contact was probably nothing. The wrist-hold in the rain was reflex. The midnight conversations were just the ordinary intimacy of hostel proximity.

And Kiran had rules for himself. The main one: Do not want things you cannot have. Do not make wanting visible.

He would keep that rule.

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He walked back to his room, sat on his bed, and opened his book to where he'd left off.

He read the same paragraph four times.

Chapter 6 — The Study Sessions Begin

It started, as most things with Arjun did, without Kiran's permission.

November arrived with the first internal exams — three weeks out, close enough to produce anxiety, far enough that most people were still pretending it wasn't real. Kiran had a system for exams the way he had a system for most things: schedule, silence, no deviation. He would begin two weeks out, work through each subject in order, take no shortcuts.

He was explaining this system to no one in particular — or rather, to Priya, who had asked and immediately stopped listening — when Arjun appeared at his hostel room door.

This was new. Arjun had never come to his room before. Kiran had gone to Arjun's wing twice — once to return a borrowed calculator, once because Arjun had texted him to come, and Kiran had gone without examining the impulse too closely. But Arjun coming here felt like a shift in direction.

Like a current changing.

"I need help with thermodynamics," Arjun said. He was leaning against the doorframe with his notebook under his arm, speaking with the directness of someone who had bypassed the part where you ask if someone is free.

Kiran's roommate, Suresh, looked up from his phone with visible interest.

"Come in," Kiran said, because there was no world in which he said the alternative.

What followed was two hours of the most distracting studying Kiran had ever done, and he was the one doing the teaching. Arjun learned differently than Kiran — not linearly, not patiently. He needed analogies. Concrete ones. Abstract rules didn't land until Kiran connected them to something physical, something Arjun could see or touch or imagine. *Entropy isn't chaos, it's just the universe preferring more options over fewer.* Arjun had stared at him for a moment after that and then said, "Why don't the textbooks say it like that?" and written it down in his own words in the margin.

Kiran watched him write and thought: he actually wants to understand. Not just pass.

He wants to know what things mean.

That was the thing no one mentioned about Arjun — the curiosity underneath the ease. Everyone saw the effortlessness and assumed it meant shallowness. But the questions Arjun asked were real questions. The kind that required thinking, not answering.

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By the second session — because there was a second session, and a third — Suresh had stopped pretending not to listen and simply joined them, and then Suresh's friend Dilip joined too, and somehow what had begun as Arjun needing thermodynamics help became a four-person study group that met every evening in Kiran's room, surrounded by textbooks and the occasional packet

of biscuits Arjun produced from nowhere.

Kiran had not planned this.

He found he didn't mind it.

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What he minded — what he privately, carefully minded — was the way Arjun had started treating his presence as default. Not in a demanding way. Just the way you treat something that is simply, reliably there. He'd drop a message: *coming at 7, tell Suresh*. He'd arrive and sit in the same spot on the edge of Kiran's bed — always that spot, like it had been assigned to him — and kick off his shoes and open his notebook and begin exactly where they'd left off.

Like they had a routine.

Kiran had a rule about wanting things he couldn't have. But no rule had prepared him for how it would feel to already have something that wasn't quite what he wanted. The proximity. The routine. The small warm weight of being someone's default.

He was grateful for it.

He was also, quietly and persistently, undone by it.

Chapter 7 — Fever

The message came at 6:43 AM on a Friday.

can't make it to lab. sick.

Kiran stared at it. He had a rule, a very clear rule, about not doing the thing he was already thinking about doing.

What kind of sick, he typed. Then deleted it.

Need anything, he typed. Deleted that too.

He put his phone down, got dressed, went to the canteen, ate breakfast, came back, picked up his phone again.

Which room, he typed.

The reply took four minutes: *207, why*

Kiran did not answer that question. He went to the pharmacy near the college gate — five-minute walk — and bought paracetamol, an electrolyte sachet, and without entirely knowing why, a small packet of glucose biscuits, because his mother had always given him glucose biscuits when he was sick and it had seemed, somehow, like the correct thing to do. He felt slightly ridiculous at the pharmacy counter. He bought them anyway.

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Room 207 was on the second floor of C block, which was Mechanical's wing. Kiran had never been this deep into it. He knocked.

"It's open," came a voice. Rougher than usual. Scraped.

Arjun was in bed, which was such a departure from every version of him Kiran had seen that it took a moment to parse. He was lying on his side, half under his blanket, phone on the pillow beside him. He looked younger. Smaller, somehow. Without the energy that usually organized the space around him, he was just a person who felt terrible.

He looked at Kiran in the doorway.

"You didn't have to," he said.

"I know," Kiran said. He set the bag down on the desk and unpacked it without ceremony — paracetamol, water bottle he'd filled at the canteen, electrolytes, biscuits. "When did it start?"

"Last night." Arjun watched him. "You bought biscuits."

"Glucose. For energy." Kiran kept his voice even. "Have you eaten anything?"

"No."

"Eat two biscuits. Then take the paracetamol."

Arjun sat up slowly. His hair was a mess, his eyes slightly glassy with fever. He took the biscuits when Kiran held them out and ate them with the obedience of someone who didn't have the energy to be contrary.

Kiran pulled the desk chair to the side of the bed and sat. He wasn't sure if he should stay. He wasn't sure if staying was reading into something that wasn't there, if it crossed a line he'd set for himself.

Arjun drank the water, took the paracetamol. Then he lay back down, turned his head toward Kiran, and said, "Stay for a bit."

Not a question. Quiet enough that it might have been fever-loosened — the kind of thing you said when your guard was down and you forgot to manage how much you were asking of people.

Kiran stayed.

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He opened his own textbook — brought out of habit, carried everywhere — and read while Arjun drifted in and out of a light sleep. The room was quiet. A ceiling fan turned slowly. Outside the window, the campus had its usual Friday morning sounds: the groundskeeper's cart, distant lecture bells, someone arguing on a phone.

At some point, Arjun said, without opening his eyes: "How do you do it?"

Kiran looked up. "Do what?"

"Just be quiet. Without it being weird."

Kiran considered this. "I don't think silence is weird. I think people are uncomfortable with it because they think it means something is wrong."

Arjun was quiet for a moment. "Most people feel the need to fill it."

"I know."

"You don't."

"No."

Another silence. Kiran went back to his textbook.

"It's nice," Arjun said. So quietly that Kiran almost didn't catch it. "The quiet. With you."

Kiran looked at the page he was reading. The words had stopped meaning anything. He read the same sentence four times and retained nothing.

He left at noon, once the fever had started coming down and Arjun had fallen into a more solid sleep. He stood in the corridor outside room 207 for a moment, leaning against the wall, and pressed the back of his hand to his own face.

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It's nice. The quiet. With you.

He walked back to his side of the hostel.

He had a rule about wanting things he couldn't have. He thought about that rule, now, and found it offered very little comfort against this particular feeling: not wanting something he didn't have, but something he already had too much of.

Chapter 8 — What Priya Sees

Priya had a way of watching people that she tried to hide and didn't, quite.

She'd been Kiran's closest friend since first year — they'd been assigned adjacent seats in Engineering Drawing and bonded over their shared belief that the subject was a form of punishment. She was perceptive in the way quiet people sometimes were, good at reading the space between what was said and what was meant.

She noticed things about Kiran that he'd hoped she wouldn't.

"You check your phone differently now," she said one afternoon in November. They were in the canteen, the slow post-lunch hour when no one was in a hurry. She had her chai. He had his.

Kiran looked up. "What?"

"When a message comes in. There's a specific way you pick up your phone now versus six months ago."

He made himself look neutral. "That's not a thing."

"It's very a thing." She wrapped both hands around her cup. "You also go quiet when he walks in somewhere. Not uncomfortable quiet. Just — aware quiet. Like you've recalibrated."

"Priya—"

"I'm not saying anything," she said, which was, Kiran reflected, exactly what someone said right before they said something. "I'm just noting. That something has changed."

He looked at his chai. This was the conversation he'd been carefully preventing for two months. Not because Priya would judge him — she wouldn't, she never had — but because saying it out loud would make it more real than he wanted it to be right now.

Real things had consequences. Real things required decisions. He wasn't ready for decisions.

"We've become friends," he said. Neutral. True.

"Yes," Priya said. "You've become friends." She let a pause sit between them. "Does he know that's not all it is for you?"

"There's nothing else for it to be."

She looked at him with the expression she used when she thought he was lying but had decided not to push. "Okay," she said.

"Priya."

"I said okay."

They drank their chai.

Later that evening, Kiran sat on the hostel rooftop — his backup thinking space when the library felt too formal for the kind of thinking he needed to do — and looked at the Hyderabad skyline going orange and pink with the sunset.

He ran a mental audit. Honest, which was harder.

Did he like Arjun? Yes. He'd admitted that in October and the admission hadn't gone away.

Was it growing? He didn't want to answer that, which was itself an answer.

Did Arjun know? No. Arjun treated him with easy warmth, with a specific kind of preference — he chose to spend time with Kiran with a frequency that was noticeable — but it read as friendship. Nothing else. Arjun was comfortable with proximity, with physical ease, with carelessness of a kind that could look like tenderness if you were looking for it.

Kiran had been, he admitted to himself now, looking for it.

Don't make wanting visible,

He thought about Priya's question. **Does he know?**

No. And it needed to stay that way.

He would not let this become something that cost him what they had. Arjun as a friend — as a constant, as an easy presence, as the person who texted **coming at 7** and showed up and sat on the edge of his bed — was already more than Kiran had expected from this year. He would not risk it.

He sat on the rooftop until the sky went fully dark and the city lights came on below him.

He was not going to say anything.

He was very decided about this.

Chapter 9 — "You're Different With Him"

The phrase came from Suresh.

Suresh was not perceptive, generally. He was cheerful and loud and occupied with his own life in a comfortable, self-contained way that Kiran had always appreciated. He was not the kind of person who noticed things.

Which made it worse, somehow, when he did.

They were in the room alone — Arjun had just left, said goodnight, done the thing where he tapped the doorframe on his way out as if he was signing off on the visit. Kiran was closing his textbooks. Suresh was eating chips and watching something on his laptop.

"Yaar," Suresh said, without looking up.

"Hmm."

"You're different with him."

Kiran paused with a textbook half-stacked. "What?"

Suresh still didn't look up. He said it the way people say obvious things: lightly, like he was commenting on the weather. "Arjun. You're different with him than you are with other people. More — I don't know. Like you're paying attention. Like everything he says actually matters."

Kiran put the textbook down. "I pay attention to people."

"Not like that." Suresh shrugged, ate a chip. "It's fine. Just noticed. He's a good guy."

"I know he's a good guy."

"Yeah." Suresh finally glanced up, briefly. "You guys are close."

"We're friends," Kiran said. The same answer he'd given Priya.

The same word, worn smooth from use.

Suresh looked at him for one moment with an unreadable expression. Then looked back at his laptop. "Sure," he said.

Sure.

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Kiran lay in bed that night and stared at the ceiling and ran through all the things he apparently wasn't hiding as well as he thought. Priya. Suresh. The list was growing. Other people could see it and Arjun — Arjun, who was perceptive in his own way, who noticed things when he was paying attention — could also potentially see it, had perhaps already seen it, was perhaps choosing not to acknowledge it because he didn't know how.

Or because there was nothing to acknowledge.

Or because—

**Stop,* Kiran told himself.*

He closed his eyes.

The thing about loving someone quietly — and he used that word now, inside his own head, in the dark, where it couldn't hurt anyone — was that it had its own particular discipline. You learned to manage the volume of it. You learned which moments you could afford to be in fully and which required a kind of interior stepping back, a slight distance between yourself and the feeling.

He was good at this, mostly.

He would be good at this.

He fell asleep to the sound of Suresh's laptop and the ceiling fan and told himself, honestly this time, that he was managing.

Chapter 10 — The First Almost-Moment

It happened on a night in December, at the edge of the semester.

The study sessions had become fewer as exams finished one by one, and there was a collective loosening in the hostel — music from open windows, people staying up late just to stay up, the specific relief of having survived another round. Arjun had knocked at 10 PM with no notebook, no pretense of studying, just two cold drinks from the machine at the hostel entrance and the suggestion that they go to the rooftop.

They went to the rooftop.

The Hyderabad December night was cool enough to make you glad for a jacket. They sat on the low parapet wall at the roof's edge — not dangerously close to the drop, just close enough to see the city laid out below them, a grid of lights extending toward the horizon. The cold drinks were orange flavor. Arjun had not asked him which one he wanted, just handed him the orange. Kiran had looked at it.

I always get orange, he thought. **He remembered I always get orange.**

"Good semester," Arjun said. He had his forearms on his knees, looking out at the city.

"It was all right."

"Liar. You aced every internal."

"You don't know that."

"Suresh told me." Arjun glanced at him sideways. Not quite smiling, but close. "He's very impressed. He talks about you like you're a phenomenon."

"He says that to be nice."

"He says it because it's true." Arjun said it simply, without decoration, and Kiran had to look away and drink his cold drink and wait for the moment to pass.

They sat in the comfortable silence that had become theirs over these months — not empty, not loaded, just easy.

Kiran had never had this with anyone before: the ability to say nothing without it meaning something was wrong.

He'd always felt the pressure to fill silence with other people. With Arjun, the silence was part of it.

"What are you doing in the break?" Arjun asked.

"Going home. Vizag." He paused. "You?"

"Delhi. My parents." He said it with the particular flatness people used for things they weren't

going to explain further.

"Okay."

"Is it?" Arjun asked. Strange question.

Kiran looked at him. "What?"

Arjun had turned, slightly. He was looking at Kiran with an expression that was harder to read than his usual — less performed, less resolved. Something a little unfinished in it. The city lights were behind him, and the December air was cool, and for a moment the whole scene felt like something on the verge of being said.

"I don't know," Arjun said. And then, very quietly: "I always feel like I should be somewhere else. Except—" He stopped.

"Except?" Kiran asked.

Arjun looked at him.

Not the glancing look he usually used. Something longer. More careful. Like he was reading something he wasn't sure he was interpreting correctly.

Four seconds. Five.

Then Arjun looked back at the city. "Except recently," he said. "Not as much as before."

- * -

It was not a confession. It was not anything, technically. It was a sentence with a gap in it where the meaning could be read any number of ways, and Kiran was very aware of how badly he wanted to read it in one particular direction.

Don't, he told himself.

He looked at the city too.

"The break will be good," Kiran said. Carefully. "Rest."

"Yeah," Arjun said.

They sat there for another half hour. The cold drinks ran out. A bike alarm went off somewhere below and then stopped.

Arjun's shoulder was close enough to Kiran's that if either of them had shifted even slightly they'd have been touching, and neither of them moved, and neither of them moved, and the stillness between them had a quality that felt like holding breath.

At 11:30, Arjun said, "We should sleep."

"Yeah."

They went back down. At the junction where the corridor split — Kiran's wing to the left, Arjun's to the right — they stopped.

Arjun looked at him for a moment.

"Safe journey," Kiran said.

"You too." A pause. "I'll message."

"Okay."

- * -

He walked back to his room and sat on his bed and pressed his hands against his face and breathed.

I'll message.

He would. Kiran already knew this. Arjun would message from the airport, from the train, from his parents' house in Delhi. Small messages, just checking in. Not because he had to. Because he did.

And that was the thing Kiran could not find a way around: Arjun chose him. Consistently, casually, without drama. He chose him in the small repeated ways that added up over months into something that felt, from the inside, like being someone's person — without the word, without the shape of it, without any of the definition that would have made it easier to understand.

Except recently. Not as much as before.

Kiran lay down. The ceiling fan turned.

He thought about the look on the rooftop. Five seconds of Arjun's eyes on his face in the December dark.

Don't read into it, he told himself.

He knew, this time, that he was losing the argument with himself.

Chapter 11 — Holiday Distance (The Messages)

The first message came at 11:22 PM on the night Kiran reached Vizag.

He'd been home for four hours. His mother had fed him rice and dal and looked at him the way mothers look at sons who've been away — like checking inventory, making sure everything was still there. His younger sister had immediately commandeered his laptop. His father had asked two questions about his grades and then retreated to the television. The house had settled into its familiar rhythms around him, and Kiran had sat on his old bed in his old room and felt, strangely, like a visitor.

His phone buzzed.

reached delhi. flight was delayed 40 mins. airport food is a crime against humanity

Kiran looked at the message for a moment. Then:

What did you eat

something that claimed to be a sandwich. it lied

You should have eaten before leaving

mom said the same thing word for word. are you two coordinating

Kiran set his phone face-down on the mattress and looked at the ceiling of his childhood room. The same ceiling he'd stared at for eighteen years — the water stain in the corner that looked like a running dog, the slight unevenness of the paint near the fan.

He picked his phone back up.

How are your parents

A longer pause this time. Three minutes.

fine. the usual. my mom made a list of things she wants to discuss. it's laminated.

Laminated.

she's very serious about lists

What's on it

internships. grades. 'life direction.' i think 'life direction' is doing a lot of heavy lifting as a category

Kiran smiled at his phone. His sister walked past his open door, glanced in, and gave him a look — the kind younger siblings perfected early, a look that said *I see you smiling at your phone and I have noted this for future use.*

He turned slightly away from the door.

When does the interrogation start

tomorrow morning. she's scheduled it. 10 AM. i have a feeling there will be a printed agenda

You'll survive

will i. kiran. will i really.

Yes.

your faith in me is touching. slightly annoying. but touching.

He lay back on his pillow. Outside his window, Vizag was doing what Vizag did in December — the sea air coming in cold and salt-tinged, the street sounds different from Hyderabad's, softer somehow. He'd missed it without knowing it.

Go sleep, he typed. *10 AM agenda requires rest.*

yeah yeah. hey

What

A pause. Longer than the others. Kiran watched the typing indicator appear and disappear twice.

nothing. goodnight kiran

Goodnight.

He put his phone down.

He lay there in the dark of his childhood room and thought about what it might have been and told himself, firmly, that he was not going to do that. He did it anyway.

- * -

The messages continued every day of the break. Not long ones. Just — consistent. Morning check-ins, random observations, complaints about family, questions about what Kiran was doing. *what do you do all day at home* — *I read. I walk on the beach. I eat my mother's food.* — *i'm jealous of all three of those things send beach pictures* — Kiran had, inexplicably, taken a photo of the beach at 6 AM and sent it, and Arjun had replied with a single word: *beautiful.*

He hadn't specified what.

Kiran had not asked.

By the end of the two-week break, Kiran had a conversation thread with Arjun that was longer than any he had with anyone else, including Priya. He noted this. He tried not to assign it too much weight and was only partially successful.

The night before they both left for Hyderabad, Arjun sent: *same train or flight*

Train, Kiran replied.

same. which one

They were on the same train. Different compartments, as it turned out — Arjun had booked later, got a different section — but the same train. Kiran sat in his seat with his book and tried to read, and somewhere around the second hour his phone buzzed: *what compartment*

He told him.

Arjun appeared twelve minutes later, dropping into the empty seat across from Kiran with his earphones around his neck and a paper cup of chai from the pantry car. He set a second cup on the little tray table between them — orange tea, slightly too hot, the kind you got on Indian trains — and said, "Figured you hadn't eaten."

Kiran looked at the chai. Then at Arjun.

"I had eaten," he said.

"Okay. So this is just chai then." Arjun settled back, one knee up, easy as always. Outside the window, the landscape was rushing past — dry December fields, the occasional flash of a town.

"What are you reading?"

He told him. Arjun took the book, looked at the cover, handed it back. "Read the first page to me."

"No."

"Why not."

"Because I'm not a radio."

Arjun grinned — the real one, the unguarded one that Kiran had categorized separately from his social smile somewhere around month two. "Fine. Tell me about it then."

So Kiran told him about the book. And somehow that turned into a conversation about stories in general — what made them work, why some characters stayed with you, what it meant when a book made you feel understood. Arjun listened and argued and made observations that were slightly sideways from what Kiran expected, and the chai went cold and the fields kept rushing past and Kiran thought:

This is the problem. This is exactly the problem.

It was too easy. Being with Arjun was too easy, and ease was dangerous because it felt like safety, and safety was the thing that made you lower guards you'd carefully built.

When they pulled into Hyderabad station at 9 PM, they walked out together through the crowd. The

city wrapped around them immediately — the noise, the auto rickshaws, the smell of the city coming back like something that had been waiting. Arjun hailed an auto first.

"Split one?" he said.

"Hostels are in the same direction," Kiran said. Which was agreement.

They sat in the back of the auto, the city rushing past, close together the way auto backseats required. Their arms were touching from shoulder to elbow. Neither of them adjusted.

Kiran looked out his side of the auto.

He thought about two weeks of daily messages and a train journey and cold chai and the typing indicator appearing and disappearing twice.

Nothing, Arjun had said. *Goodnight.*

He looked at the city lights.

It's fine, he told himself. *This is fine.*

The hostel gates appeared ahead. The auto slowed.

Chapter 12 — Return

Semester two started with a shift.

Kiran noticed it slowly, the way you notice a change in weather — not in one moment but in accumulation. The study group continued. The late nights continued. The easy routine of Arjun appearing at his door continued.

But something had moved.

He couldn't name it precisely. Arjun was the same — warm, effortless, casually present. But there was a quality to his attention now that felt different from before the break. More deliberate. Like he was making choices that he'd been making automatically before and now was making consciously.

Small things:

When they walked somewhere together, Arjun matched his pace now. Before, he'd always walked slightly ahead — not rudely, just naturally, the pace of someone accustomed to leading. Now he fell into step beside Kiran. Exactly beside. Like he'd recalibrated.

In the study group, when someone said something that made the group laugh, Arjun looked at Kiran first. Not at the person who'd spoken. Not at the group. At Kiran, to see if he'd laughed too.

Once, in the library — they went to the library together now, routinely, Kiran's original seat expanded by default to include Arjun in the adjacent chair — Arjun had reached over without looking up from his textbook and pushed Kiran's water bottle closer to his side of the table. Because Kiran had reached for it twice without getting it. He'd done it absently, automatically. Like it was already a habit.

Kiran had looked at the water bottle for a long moment.

Then he'd drunk from it and said nothing.

- * -

He talked about none of this to Priya. She would have thoughts about it, and her thoughts would be accurate, and accuracy was not something he could afford right now.

Continuing to exist in the space that had opened between them over the past months with the care and attention of someone walking a path they couldn't see fully.

He was good at that, at least.

Chapter 13 — Close

The night it snowed in Kiran's chest — that was how he'd describe it later, to himself, in the privacy of his own head — was an ordinary Tuesday.

Late February. The study group had disbanded early because Suresh had a phone call with his girlfriend that he'd been postponing for three days and could no longer delay. Dilip had gone with him for moral support, which Kiran found conceptually unclear but didn't question. And so it was just the two of them in Kiran's room, which had happened before, many times — but tonight Arjun didn't seem to be in any hurry to leave.

He was lying on Kiran's bed.

This was not new either. Arjun had a casual relationship with horizontal surfaces — he'd stretch out on Kiran's bed with his textbook the way some people sat in chairs, like it was simply the most comfortable option and therefore the obvious one. Kiran had stopped reacting to it around month three. He'd been quite proud of that.

Tonight, though, Arjun wasn't reading. He'd put his textbook aside and was lying on his back, one arm behind his head, looking at the ceiling. The room was quiet. The fan turned slowly. Outside, someone was playing music two floors down — something old, a Hindi song Kiran half-recognized.

Kiran was at his desk, pretending to write notes.

"Hey," Arjun said.

"Hmm."

"Come here."

Kiran turned slightly. "What?"

Arjun didn't look at him. Just gestured, vaguely, at the bed beside him. The space he was not occupying. "Stop writing. Come sit."

"I'm working."

"You've been staring at the same page for twenty minutes."

Kiran had been staring at the same page for twenty minutes. He closed the notebook, pushed his chair back, and crossed to the bed. He sat against the headboard, legs stretched, leaving a careful foot of space between them.

Arjun glanced at him. The foot of space. Back at the ceiling.

They stayed like that. The music from downstairs continued — slow, something with a lot of feeling in it. Kiran looked at the wall opposite. He was very aware of the warmth radiating from Arjun's side of the bed. He was very aware of the foot of space.

"Do you ever feel like," Arjun started, then stopped.

"Like what."

"Like you're waiting for something. But you don't know what."

Kiran thought about this. "Yes," he said.

"Does it go away?"

"I don't know yet."

Arjun was quiet for a moment. The music from downstairs had shifted — the same singer, different song. Still slow.

"I think I understand what you meant," Arjun said. "About silence not being weird."

Kiran looked at him now. Arjun was still looking at the ceiling, but something in his expression was open in the way it got when he'd had a thought he hadn't planned on having.

"What made you think about that?" Kiran asked.

"Being at home." A pause. "My house is very loud. My parents talk all the time. At each other, around each other. Even the silence there is loud, somehow. Like everyone is performing not-speaking." He exhaled slowly. "Here it's different."

Here. In this room. Kiran's room.

"Good different?" Kiran asked.

Arjun finally turned his head and looked at him. They were not far apart — the foot of space was not actually that much, and Arjun had turned fully onto his side now, head on the pillow, looking up at Kiran from below. His expression was one Kiran had been cataloguing all year and still didn't have a complete reading of: something open, something searching, something that was looking for an answer to a question it hadn't fully formed yet.

"Yeah," Arjun said. Quietly. "Good different."

Four seconds.

Kiran looked back at the wall.

His heart was doing something he would describe to no one.

"Sleep," he said. His voice came out even. He was proud of this.

"I'm not tired."

"You're lying on my bed staring at the ceiling. That's the beginning of tired."

Arjun didn't argue. He stayed on his side, facing Kiran. "Tell me something," he said. Eyes half-

closed now.

"What."

"Anything. Your voice is—" He stopped. Reconsidered. "Just talk. About anything."

Your voice is—

Kiran pressed the back of his hand briefly to his mouth.

Then he talked. He talked about the book he was reading. He talked about the sea in Vizag in December, the way the light came off it in the early morning. He talked about a paper he'd read once about the way birds navigated using the earth's magnetic field, how they could sense things humans had no instrument for.

Arjun's eyes closed fully somewhere in the middle of the birds.

His breathing slowed.

He'd fallen asleep.

- * -

Kiran sat against the headboard in the quiet room, Arjun asleep at his side, the music from downstairs soft and plaintive, and let himself feel — just for a moment, just for the private length of that moment — everything he'd been carefully managing since October.

It was a lot.

He breathed through it.

Then he carefully got up, turned the desk lamp off so only the faint corridor light came under the door, and sat back down. He picked up his book and read by the low light until Arjun woke at midnight, disoriented, and said "oh — sorry, I —" and Kiran said "it's fine" and Arjun looked at him for a moment with his hair messed from sleep and said, quietly, *"thanks"* and left.

- * -

Kiran sat in the dark afterward.

Your voice is —

He never found out what came after that sentence.

He thought about it for a long time.

Chapter 14 — Third Person

His name was Rohan.

He arrived in March — a friend of Priya's from her hometown, visiting campus for a week for some inter-college event. He was tall, easy-going, studying literature somewhere in Pune, the kind of person who had strong opinions about films and held them lightly, willing to be argued with. He was, objectively, good company.

He also, within twelve hours of arriving, attached himself to Kiran with a directness that Kiran found both flattering and mildly alarming.

'You're interesting,' Rohan told him on the second day, in the canteen, with no preamble. 'Priya said you were quiet. She didn't say you were interesting.'

'Those aren't mutually exclusive,' Kiran said.

'No, but people usually lead with one or the other.' Rohan had Kiran's book — he'd picked it up off the table to look at it, which Kiran would have found annoying from most people but had somehow not minded. 'Can I sit here?'

'You're already sitting.'

'Fair point.'

Rohan sat with them at lunch. He sat with them in the evening too, at the campus coffeehouse that existed in a converted classroom and charged too much for filter coffee. He was good at drawing Kiran into conversation — not forcing it, not performing interest, just genuinely curious in a way that created space for Kiran to respond.

Kiran did not think anything of it until the third day.

They were in the campus coffee house again, just the two of them this time — Priya had vanished somewhere with her own business — and Rohan said, in the middle of a conversation about something else entirely, 'Are you seeing anyone?'

Kiran looked at him.

'No,' he said.

Rohan nodded, like this was information he'd been waiting for and now had. He went back to his coffee. And then, after a moment: 'I'm here until Sunday.'

'I know,' Kiran said.

'Okay,' Rohan said. Leaving whatever door he'd opened — open.

Kiran went back to the hostel that evening and thought about it with the careful attention he gave to things that required decisions. Rohan was. He was available, clearly interested, genuinely enjoyable

to talk to. There was no reason, objectively, to close that door.

There was no reason, objectively, to close that door.

Except that the door already felt closed. Not by Rohan.

By Kiran's own interior geography, which had been reorganizing itself around one person for the past six months and didn't have room for reconfiguration right now.

He was in the middle of this thought when his phone buzzed.

- * -

where are you

Arjun.

Coffee house, he typed. Then, because Arjun would ask: *Just left actually. Walking back.*

come to the roof

He went to the roof.

Arjun was there already, leaning against the parapet, and he looked at Kiran when he came through the roof door with an expression that was — off. Slightly. Something tighter than usual around the edges.

'Who was that,' he said.

Kiran blinked. 'Who was what.'

'The guy. Priya's friend. You've been with him the last three days.'

'Rohan. Priya's friend from Pune.' He looked at Arjun. 'How did you know I was with him.'

A pause. Arjun looked away, out over the city. 'Suresh mentioned it.'

'Suresh mentioned it.'

'Yeah.'

Kiran watched him for a moment. Arjun's jaw was slightly set. He was doing the thing he did when something had unsettled him and he'd decided not to name it — looking at the middle distance, arms folded, the ease of him slightly contracted.

He was doing the thing he did when something had unsettled him and he'd decided not to name it — looking at the middle distance, arms folded, the ease of him slightly contracted.

'He's here for an event,' Kiran said. 'He leaves Sunday.'

'Okay.'

'We've had coffee a couple of times.'

'That's fine.' Arjun said it too quickly. Then, after a pause: 'Is he—' He stopped.

'Is he what.'

'Nothing.' Arjun unfolded his arms. Looked at Kiran. The tightness was still there but he'd smoothed something over it, back to his usual surface. 'Nothing. Never mind.'

He didn't mention Rohan again that night.

But the night had a different quality to it — Arjun stayed on the roof longer than he normally would have, and he talked more than he usually did in their quiet together, filling space the way he normally didn't. And when they finally said goodnight he touched Kiran's shoulder briefly, just a hand, just a second, before heading to his wing.

Kiran stood at the corridor junction.

He understood, with the part of him that had been paying close attention for months, what he had just witnessed.

He didn't let himself decide what it meant.

He went to bed. He slept badly.

- * -

On Sunday, Rohan left. He said goodbye to Kiran with a look that was pleasant and slightly rueful and said, 'If you're ever in Pune,' and Kiran said 'sure,' and that was that.

He told none of this to Arjun.

Arjun, the following Monday, was back to himself — easy, warm, knocking at 7 PM with his notebook and sitting in his spot on Kiran's bed. Like nothing had shifted.

Like something had, and he'd decided not to look at it.

Chapter 15 — Arjun Gets Jealous (Doesn't Know What to Call It)

March stretched on. The weather shifted — Hyderabad moving from winter cool into the slow build of summer, temperatures climbing by degree, the air thickening. Hostel life adjusted: more time on the rooftop at night, more cold drinks from the vending machine, fans on at full speed.

The shift in Arjun happened gradually enough that Kiran almost didn't track it.

Almost.

He tracked it.

What he observed, over two weeks of careful and completely unacknowledged observation:

When they were in a group and someone else — anyone, male or female, it didn't seem to matter — drew Kiran into conversation specifically, Arjun noticed. He didn't do anything about it. Didn't interrupt or redirect. But his attention moved in a way it hadn't used to. He tracked the exchange. He came back to Kiran shortly after, casually, as if pulled by magnetism.

Once, in the canteen, a girl from Kiran's class — Aditi, good-natured and direct — sat down next to Kiran and started asking him something about an assignment. Standard. Kiran answered. Arjun, across the table, became very interested in his food for approximately ninety seconds and then said, apropos of nothing, "Kiran, didn't you say you needed to go to the library after this?" — which Kiran had not said. He looked at Arjun. Arjun looked back at him with perfect composure.

"No," Kiran said.

"Oh," Arjun said. "Thought you did." Back to his food.

Another time: they were walking back from a lecture, a small group of them, and someone had started talking to Kiran and naturally drawn him to the side of the group away from Arjun. And Kiran had, a few minutes later, felt a hand at his back — brief, light, just fingers between his shoulder blades, the way you'd redirect someone's attention in a crowd. He turned. Arjun was beside him again.

"Thought I lost you," Arjun said.

He said it lightly. With a half-smile. Like it was a joke.

His hand left Kiran's back after one more second.

Kiran told himself: *This is not what you think it is. You are reading into it. He's tactile with everyone. He doesn't know what he's doing.*

But that was the thing — Kiran watched, and Arjun was not tactile with everyone. He was easy and warm with people, yes. But the specific texture of the way he touched Kiran was different. Casual but precise. Like he knew exactly where his own hands were.

One night on the roof — their roof now, definitively theirs, the place they ended up when the evening wound down — Kiran was sitting on the parapet, looking at the city, and Arjun came and sat beside him. Close. Closer than he needed to, given the length of the parapet. Their shoulders touching.

Kiran didn't adjust.

Arjun didn't adjust.

"Tell me something you haven't told anyone," Arjun said.

The challenge of this sentence was that it invited honesty and honesty was a door Kiran couldn't afford to walk through fully.

"I don't like large groups," Kiran said. Which was true, and safe. "Not because I dislike people. Because I can't track everyone well enough. It's exhausting not being able to pay full attention to each person."

"You pay full attention to people?"

"When I can. Yes."

Arjun was quiet for a moment. Their shoulders were still touching. The city below was its usual complicated glittering self.

"Is that what you do with me?" Arjun asked. Carefully. Like the question was slightly more loaded than its surface.

Kiran looked at him.

The city lights were reflected in Arjun's eyes. He was close enough that Kiran could see the detail of his face clearly — the slight shadow of stubble, the line of his jaw, the way he was watching Kiran with that expression that Kiran had catalogued and still couldn't fully decode.

"Yes," Kiran said.

Arjun's gaze held his for a moment.

Then — slowly, without breaking eye contact — he reached over and moved Kiran's hand from where it was braced on the parapet wall. He didn't do anything with it. He just placed his own hand over it, loosely, and looked back out at the city.

His hand over Kiran's on the parapet wall.

Not holding. Just — there.

Kiran breathed.

Don't move, he told himself. *Don't read into it. Don't make anything of this.*

But Arjun's hand stayed there for fifteen minutes. Neither of them spoke. The city did its glittering, indifferent thing below them. A breeze moved through, warm and city-scented.

- * -

When they finally went back inside, Arjun did not mention what had happened. He said goodnight at the corridor junction with his usual ease, tapped the wall, and disappeared toward his wing.

Kiran stood at the junction.

His hand felt different. The hand Arjun had covered. Like it had been given something it didn't know how to carry yet.

He stood there long enough that Suresh opened their room door from the inside and said, "Are you just going to stand in the corridor, or—"

"Coming," Kiran said.

He went in.

He sat on his bed.

He thought about the question Arjun had asked — **is that what you do with me** — and the way he'd held Kiran's gaze while waiting for the answer. And the hand. The fifteen minutes of the hand.

He doesn't know what he's doing, Kiran thought.

And then, more quietly, more honestly:

Maybe he's starting to.

Chapter 16 — The Almost (First)

It was the kind of night that had no reason to be significant.

No special occasion. No particular conversation that had been building toward it. Just a regular Friday in late March, the semester winding toward its last stretch, the heat beginning its slow Hyderabad climb. Suresh was at his girlfriend's hostel — a carefully negotiated visit that had required three days of planning and one bribed warden. The room was empty.

Arjun came at nine.

He had two cups of tea from the canteen, brought up in the flimsy plastic cups that never quite held the heat long enough. He handed one to Kiran at the door and walked in without being invited, which had stopped requiring an invitation sometime in December. He sat on the bed. Kiran sat at his desk. The ceiling fan turned at medium speed. Through the window, the campus was doing its Friday evening thing — music somewhere, voices, the distant bass of someone's speaker.

They talked about nothing important. That was the thing about their evenings now — the conversation didn't need to go anywhere. It wandered. Tonight it went from the semester exams to a documentary Arjun had watched on his phone to a hypothetical argument about whether it was possible to be genuinely happy in a job you were indifferent to.

"Yes," Kiran said. "If other things are good."

"That sounds like settling."

"That sounds like perspective."

"You're very calm about compromising."

"You're very dramatic about not having to."

Arjun pointed at him. "That's the most direct thing you've said to me in weeks."

"It's not direct. It's accurate."

"Same thing, coming from you."

Kiran looked at him. Arjun was grinning — not the social grin, the real one, slightly crooked on the left side, the one that meant he was genuinely entertained and not performing it. He was sitting cross-legged on the bed now, tea finished, one of Kiran's books open in his lap — not reading it, just holding it, turning it over like an object.

"Can I ask you something?" Arjun said.

"You usually do regardless."

"Fair." He looked down at the book for a moment. Then up. "Do you ever want things you don't say?"

The room temperature did not change. Kiran was fairly sure of this. And yet.

"Everyone does," he said.

"That's not an answer."

"It's a true statement."

"Kiran." Arjun's voice was different. Slightly lower. Like he'd made a decision to take the conversation somewhere and was now in it. "I'm asking you specifically."

Kiran held his gaze. "Yes," he said. "I want things I don't say."

"Like what."

In the room there was just the question and Kiran's knowledge of how dangerous the honest answer was.

"Things I can't have," he said finally. "So saying them would just be—" He paused. "Unnecessary weight."

Arjun was very still.

"What if you could have them," he said.

Kiran looked at him.

Arjun had uncrossed his legs. He was sitting at the edge of the bed now, leaning slightly forward, and his expression — that expression, the one Kiran had been cataloguing for months — was at its most unguarded. The question was not rhetorical. He was waiting for an answer with the focus of someone who had decided to wait for it regardless of how long it took.

- * -

Kiran's heart was doing something structural. Something that felt like a building settling.

"I don't know," he said. Because it was true. Because **what if you could have them** was a question he had not allowed himself to answer, had in fact built entire interior walls against answering, and those walls did not come down in one Friday evening no matter how quiet the room was or how Arjun was looking at him.

Arjun nodded slowly. Like he'd expected this and was deciding what to do with it.

He stood up.

For one moment — three seconds, four — he was standing very close to where Kiran was sitting. Close enough that Kiran could see the detail of him clearly: the rise and fall of his chest, the line of his collarbone where his collar sat open, the way he was looking down at Kiran with that expression that was asking something it hadn't put into words yet.

Kiran did not move.

Arjun reached out.

He tucked a strand of Kiran's hair back — there was always one piece that fell forward, a thing Kiran had never bothered to fix — with two fingers, slow and deliberate, and let his hand rest for one moment against Kiran's temple.

One moment.

Then he stepped back.

"Goodnight, Kiran," he said. Quietly. Something in his voice that Kiran had not heard before — something careful, like he was holding something gently.

He left.

- * -

Kiran sat in his chair.

He pressed his hand to his own temple where Arjun's fingers had been.

He sat there for a very long time.

Chapter 17 — Morning After (Nothing Happened, But Something Did)

He woke at 5:43 AM.

Not because of an alarm. Because something in him had not fully gone to sleep — had stayed at the surface, turning the evening over and over with the relentless patience of water working at stone.

Arjun's hand against his temple.

What if you could have them.

He lay in the pale pre-dawn dark of his room and conducted an honest inventory. This was something he did when things became complicated — stripped everything back to what was actually true and what was assumption.

True: Arjun had asked him what he wanted. Had pressed when Kiran gave a non-answer. Had looked at him with something that was not casual or friendly or ambiguous in the way things had been ambiguous before.

True: Arjun had touched his face. Deliberately. Slowly.

Assumption: that this meant what Kiran wanted it to mean.

This was the problem. This was always the problem. Arjun operated in a register of warmth and physical ease that was native to him — he touched people, he got close, he made people feel chosen without necessarily meaning anything specific by it. Kiran had watched him do this with others, had catalogued it, had reminded himself of it every time he felt the pull of misinterpretation.

But the question.

What if you could have them.

That was not casual. That was not ambient warmth. That was a specific question asked directly at Kiran, with Arjun's full attention, waiting for an answer.

He stared at the ceiling.

- * -

Suresh returned at seven, moving quietly, apparently under the impression that Kiran was asleep. Kiran kept his eyes closed and let him think so.

His phone was face-down on the mattress beside him. He hadn't looked at it since last night. He turned it over now.

No message from Arjun.

He put it back down.

This was fine. This was — they didn't always message in the mornings. There was no established pattern that required a morning message. The absence of a message meant nothing.

By nine AM he was dressed, had eaten breakfast, and had written exactly two lines of the assignment due next week. Both were bad. He deleted them.

His phone buzzed.

are you going to the library today

He exhaled. Looked at the message. Looked at it for longer than it required.

Later, he typed. After lunch.

okay. I'll come.

Not can I come. I'll come. Default. Still default.

Kiran put his phone in his pocket and went back to his assignment and managed, this time, to write four lines that were not bad.

- * -

They met at the library at two. Arjun was already there when Kiran arrived — in the adjacent chair, Kiran's chair already holding his bag as a placeholder, which meant he'd arrived first and saved it, which meant he'd been thinking about where Kiran sat. Kiran set his bag down and opened his laptop and did not look at Arjun directly for the first minute.

Arjun said nothing about last night.

Kiran said nothing about last night.

They studied. The library did its quiet thing around them. At some point Arjun's foot found Kiran's under the table — not obviously, just a brush of shoe against shoe, and then the pressure of it staying there, Arjun's foot against his.

Like an anchor.

He didn't move his foot.

Arjun didn't move his.

They stayed like that for two hours. Studying. Saying nothing. Feet touching under the table in the quiet library, and the whole afternoon had the quality of something that existed in the space between what had been said and what hadn't yet.

When they left, walking back to the hostel, Arjun fell into step beside him. Their arms brushed with every other step the way they did now — familiar, constant, neither of them adjusting.

"Kiran," Arjun said.

"Hmm."

A pause. Long enough that Kiran looked at him.

Arjun was looking ahead, at the path. Something working in his expression — not resolved yet, not ready yet.

"Nothing," he said.

Like the message over the holiday. Nothing. Goodnight.

Kiran nodded. "Okay."

They walked back.

- * -

But Arjun's hand found his wrist as they reached the hostel gate — not holding, just fingers around bone, one brief second — and then let go.

Nothing happened.

Something did.

Chapter 18 — Arjun Starts Noticing Noticing

Here is what Arjun did not say, because Arjun did not yet have language for it:

I notice everything about you.

He would not have said this. It would have sounded wrong coming out, too much, the kind of thing you said in films and not in hostel corridors. But it was true in a way that had been sneaking up on him for months, the truth of it arriving incrementally, the way you don't notice a city changing until you see a photograph from before.

He noticed: the specific way Kiran held a pen. Loosely, like he'd made peace with the instrument. The way he tilted his head when something interested him — not much, just a degree, like he was angling toward it. The way he laughed — rare, but when it came, complete. Not a performance of laughter. The actual thing.

He noticed: Kiran always finished his food. Unlike most of their group, who left something on the plate, Kiran ate everything. Arjun had found this fascinating and then stopped examining why he found it fascinating.

He noticed: which silences Kiran was comfortable in and which he wasn't. With strangers, his silences had a slight tension — not anxiety, more like management, like he was holding himself at a careful distance. With Arjun, the silence was different. Loose. Like he'd put something down.

Like he'd put something down.

Arjun sat with that observation one evening in April, alone on the roof because Kiran had gone to bed early with a headache, and he sat with it the way he sat with problems in engineering — turning it until the structure became clear.

He was not, he told himself, someone who examined his own feelings with great care. He moved through the world largely on instinct, had found that instinct usually served him well. He did not have a complex relationship with himself.

And yet.

He thought about the night in Kiran's room. The question he'd asked. **What if you could have them.** He'd asked it because — because why. Because something had built over months to the point where not asking felt wrong. Because Kiran's face, when he talked about things he wanted but didn't say, did something to Arjun's chest that he hadn't encountered before and hadn't been able to classify.

What had he expected Kiran to say?

He wasn't sure. He'd asked the question before he'd thought about where the answer would leave them.

Kiran had said: *I don't know.*

And Arjun had — what. Touched his face. Like it was the only available response. Like his hands had understood something his brain was still processing.

He leaned back on his palms on the rooftop.

The city spread below him, indifferent and electric.

- * -

He did not think about other people the way he thought about Kiran.

He did not track other people's silences or the angle of their heads or the specific quality of their laughter. He did not feel the particular restlessness he felt when Kiran wasn't in the room — not loneliness exactly, more like a background frequency going missing.

He did not, when other people talked to someone else, feel the thing he'd felt watching Kiran with Rohan. That tight, directionless thing with no proper name.

He thought about the names for it.

He tried several on and found them all slightly ill-fitting, like clothes from someone else's wardrobe.

And then one of them fit.

Not perfectly. Not without resistance. But it fit.

He sat on the roof for a long time.

- * -

When he went back to his room, he lay in bed and looked at the ceiling and thought about Kiran's face in the low light of that room, the way he'd looked back at Arjun with those careful, honest eyes.

Things I can't have, Kiran had said. *So saying them would just be unnecessary weight.*

Arjun closed his eyes.

What if he meant—

He pressed the thought down. He wasn't ready. He was getting there, moving toward something — but he wasn't ready to arrive yet, and he knew the difference between insight and readiness.

He slept badly.

- * -

In the morning, he texted Kiran: *are you going to the library today.*

Chapter 19 — What Kiran Doesn't Say

April.

The evenings were warm now, properly warm, the kind that made the rooftop bearable only after 9 PM. They'd adjusted: library in the afternoons, rooftop after dark, the city doing its summer thing below them.

Things had shifted again. Subtly. Like a tide moving — you didn't see it happening, only the difference in the waterline.

Arjun touched him more.

Not dramatically. Not in ways that announced themselves. But the frequency had changed — the hand at his back in a crowd, the shoulder against his in the auto, the foot under the table in the library that had become a standing habit neither of them acknowledged. Once, when Kiran had fallen asleep at his desk during a late study session, he'd woken to find a blanket over his shoulders — his own blanket, from his bed. Arjun had been on his phone on the bed across the room, and when Kiran looked at him, he just said "you looked cold" without looking up, and went back to his phone.

Kiran had looked at the blanket on his shoulders.

He had not said anything.

Just because the act of noticing was the only honest thing he could do with all of it.

- * -

Priya asked him, in April, while they were walking back from a lecture: "What's happening with you and Arjun?"

"What do you mean."

"I mean you have the look of someone in the middle of something."

"I'm always in the middle of something."

"Not like this." She looked at him sideways. "He came and sat with us at lunch yesterday specifically because you were there. He didn't know anyone else at the table. He stayed for forty-five minutes."

"He's sociable."

"Kiran. He sat next to you and spent the whole time in a conversation with just you."

Kiran walked. The campus was loud around them, the afternoon break rush.

"I don't know what's happening," he said. Which was the most honest answer. He genuinely didn't

know. He had evidence. He had patterns. He had fifteen minutes of a hand over his on a parapet wall and a strand of hair tucked back with two careful fingers and *what if you could have them* — and he still did not know, because knowing required certainty and certainty required a conversation he did not know how to have.

"You could ask him," Priya said.

"Ask him what."

She gave him the look. The one that said *you know exactly what.*

"Priya."

"I'm just saying. You're both doing this very elaborate dance and at some point someone has to—"

"Stop."

"I'm stopping." She stopped. For four steps. "Just — Kiran. You're allowed to want things."

He looked at her.

She looked back steadily, no agenda in it, just the particular kindness of someone who had been watching someone she cared about manage themselves into smallness for too long.

"I know," he said quietly.

"Do you?"

He didn't answer.

She didn't push.

- * -

That night, on the rooftop, he sat beside Arjun in the usual dark and thought about what Priya had said. *You're allowed to want things.* He'd built so much of himself around the management of wanting — around the discipline of desire, the careful rationing of hope — that the idea of simply allowing it felt like being handed something he didn't know how to hold.

Arjun was quiet beside him. He'd been slightly quieter lately, in general — not withdrawn, just thoughtful in a way that was new. Like something was working in him below the surface.

"Hey," Arjun said.

"Hmm."

"If I asked you something. Would you answer honestly?"

Kiran looked at him. "I always answer honestly."

"No. You answer carefully." He met Kiran's eyes. "Those are different things."

The distinction landed. Kiran felt it land.

"Okay," he said.

Arjun held his gaze for a moment. Something assembling behind his eyes.

And then — something in him shifted. Receded. Like he'd gotten to the edge of it and stepped back.

"Never mind," he said.

He looked back at the city.

Kiran breathed.

"Arjun."

"Hmm."

"You do that," Kiran said. Carefully. "You get to the edge of something and you step back."

Arjun was quiet.

"I do it too," Kiran said. "I know what it looks like from the inside."

Arjun turned. He was looking at Kiran with an expression that was, for once, entirely without its usual surface — no ease, no management, no performance of composure. Just whatever was actually there.

"I'm not ready yet," Arjun said. Quietly. "But I'm— I'm getting there."

Getting there.

Kiran looked at him. At the honesty in his face. At the person he'd been watching for seven months, who was looking back at him right now with something fragile and genuine and slightly frightened.

"Okay," Kiran said.

"Okay?"

"Okay." He looked back at the city.

I'll be here.

Three words. The simplest possible sentence. He felt them leave him and felt, after, the particular lightness of having said something true.

Arjun didn't say anything for a long moment.

Then his hand found Kiran's again. Not over it this time — fingers sliding between fingers. Properly. Warm.

Kiran looked down at their joined hands on the parapet wall.

He didn't move. He didn't speak.

He just stayed. The way he'd said he would.

Chapter 20 — The Photograph

The photograph was an accident.

College fest, second night. Someone was going around with a camera — an actual camera, not a phone, a film camera that a photography club kid had been shooting on all week. Kiran had been standing at the edge of the amphitheater crowd watching the second year performance when Arjun had appeared behind him — materializing the way he'd learned to, appearing at Kiran's shoulder without announcement, close enough that Kiran felt the warmth of him before he saw him.

"You're watching again," Arjun said. Low, into his ear, because the music was loud.

"So are you," Kiran said.

"I'm watching you watch."

Kiran turned his head slightly. Arjun was right there — closer than usual even for them, because of the crowd pressing around them, or maybe not because of the crowd. His face was turned toward the stage but his eyes had moved to Kiran.

The camera went off.

Neither of them noticed.

- * -

The photograph existed for three weeks before Kiran saw it. The photography kid — Ishaan, second year, enthusiastic — posted a set of festival shots on the department group and Kiran scrolled through them three days later out of mild curiosity.

He stopped.

The photograph was slightly blurred at the edges — film, so the sharpness sat where it sat and didn't extend everywhere. The stage was in the background, the crowd a soft mass of motion. In the foreground, slightly to the left: two people. One facing partly away, head tilted as if caught mid-turn. The other — closer, face slightly in profile — looking not at the stage but at the first person.

The first person was Kiran.

The second person, looking at him, was Arjun.

It was the expression.

Kiran had spent seven months reading Arjun's expressions, cataloguing them, translating them with varying success. He knew the social smile and the real one, the thoughtful look and the distracted one, the quiet on the rooftop and the quiet in the library.

He had not seen this expression before.

Or rather — he had seen pieces of it. In the room, the night of the almost. On the roof, the night of the hand. In fragments, in half-seconds, in glimpses that were gone before he could be sure he'd seen them.

But here it was, fixed in silver chemistry on a photograph, unable to move or recede or be taken back.

The way Arjun was looking at him.

It was not casual. It was not ambient warmth. It was not friendship.

It was the expression of someone watching something they were afraid of losing.

Kiran sat with his phone for a long time.

- * -

He didn't send the photograph to anyone. He didn't mention it. He saved it to his phone quietly, the way you kept something that needed to be kept, and he put his phone in his pocket and went to the canteen and ate lunch and came back and sat at his desk.

That evening Arjun came at seven.

He sat in his spot on Kiran's bed. He opened his notebook. He looked up at Kiran with the expression he usually had in this room — open, easy, home.

He did not know about the photograph.

Kiran looked at him and thought about the image of Arjun's face turned toward him in a crowd, with the stage lights behind and the film grain soft around it, and that expression — that expression — that had been there without Arjun knowing it was there.

The expression of someone watching something they're afraid of losing.

"What?" Arjun said, noticing him looking.

"Nothing," Kiran said.

He sat down.

- * -

But something had settled in him. Something had become, quietly, certain. Not in a dramatic way — not in a way that required action immediately or changed the texture of this evening or any of the evenings to follow. Just certain the way facts were certain.

Arjun was getting there.

And Kiran would be here.

Whatever came next, he would be here.

Chapter 21 — Inseparable (The World Notices)

The word came from Dilip.

He said it the way people said obvious things — casually, between bites, in the middle of lunch, without any awareness that he was naming something that had been building for eight months.

"You two are inseparable, yaar."

He was talking to Suresh. Not even to Kiran or Arjun directly. Just — observing, the way Dilip occasionally surfaced from his usual comfortable fog to notice something about the world around him and comment on it without filter.

Arjun was at the vending machine. Kiran was three seats away. Neither of them had been doing anything particularly notable — they'd arrived at the canteen separately, sat in adjacent seats by default, and were now existing in the easy parallel the way they always did. Nothing dramatic. Nothing that should have required a word.

And yet.

Inseparable.

Suresh made a noncommittal sound and went back to his food. Dilip moved on to complaining about the afternoon lab. The moment passed.

But Kiran had heard it.

He looked at his plate. He was careful not to look at Arjun, who was returning from the vending machine now, setting an orange cold drink on the table beside Kiran's hand without asking, without looking, just — placing it there the way you placed something that had always belonged there.

Kiran looked at the cold drink.

He picked it up. Drank. Said nothing.

Arjun sat down and resumed the conversation he'd been having with Suresh before the vending machine detour, completely unbothered, completely unaware that a single word had just rearranged something in Kiran's chest.

Or maybe he'd heard it too.

- * -

Maybe that was why his knee was now pressing lightly against Kiran's under the table — not the foot-against-foot of the library, something more direct than that, the solid warmth of it staying there through the rest of lunch while Arjun talked and laughed and performed his usual easy social self.

A knee against a knee.

Like an answer to a question neither of them had asked out loud.

Kiran ate his lunch. He did not move his knee. He did not look at Arjun. He looked at his plate and felt the warmth of that contact like a frequency running through him and thought:

Inseparable.

Maybe Dilip, for once in his comfortable foggy life, had gotten something exactly right.

Chapter 22 — "Just Friends" — The Phrase That Cuts

It happened three days after Dilip's observation, which meant Kiran was still carrying the word inseparable in the pocket of his chest when he heard the other thing.

He hadn't meant to overhear it.

He'd come to return a book to Arjun's wing — a textbook Arjun had left in Kiran's room two days ago, which Kiran had been meaning to return and kept not returning for reasons he wasn't examining. He was at the end of the corridor, about to knock on 207, when he heard voices inside. Arjun's. And someone else — a girl, familiar enough that after a second Kiran placed her: Simran, from Arjun's friend group, someone Kiran had met three or four times and never thought much about.

He wasn't going to listen.

He was already raising his hand to knock when the words arrived through the thin door with perfect, terrible clarity.

"—the way you are with him, Arjun. People notice."

A pause. Arjun's voice, slightly different from his usual register. More careful.

"He's my friend, Simran."

"I know he's your friend. I'm saying it looks like—"

"He's just my friend."

Four words.

He's just my friend.

Said without hesitation. Said with the particular firmness of someone closing a door — not angrily, just definitively. The way you said something you'd decided was the truth.

Kiran lowered his hand.

He stood in the corridor for exactly four seconds. He counted them without meaning to, the way you counted things when your brain was looking for something to do that wasn't feeling.

Then he turned around.

- * -

He walked back down the corridor. Down the stairs. Across the quad. Into his own room, which was empty because Suresh was at class. He set the textbook on the desk — Arjun's textbook, which he'd been carrying around for two days — and sat on the edge of his bed.

He's just my friend.

He sat with that for a long time.

Here was the thing about hearing it — the specific cruelty of it wasn't in the words themselves. Arjun hadn't said anything that was technically untrue. They were friends. Kiran had known this. Had held it as a fact, had built structures around it, had reminded himself of it every time he'd felt himself drifting toward interpretation.

The cruelty was in the just.

Just a friend. As if the past eight months — the roof, the silence, the knee under the table, the photograph, fingers between fingers, properly — were reducible to that. Just. A modifier that minimized. A word that made something large into something small.

He lay back on his bed.

He stared at the ceiling. The fan turned. The campus sounds came in through the window — ordinary, indifferent, continuing.

He thought about Priya's question: does he know it's not just that for you.

He thought about his answer: there's nothing else for it to be.

He had been so careful. He had managed wanting so precisely, had given himself only what was allowed, had stayed within the edges he'd drawn. And still — somehow — it hurt like this. Like something being taken that you'd never been told you had.

He's just my friend.

Okay, Kiran thought. Okay.

He would be just a friend.

He had been practicing for months. He was good at it.

He closed his eyes.

- * -

When Arjun knocked at seven that evening — the usual time, the usual knock, two-one pattern that Kiran could identify from three rooms away — Kiran opened the door and let him in and was normal. He was warm and present and gave nothing away. He asked about the thermodynamics assignment. He made tea on the hotplate. He sat at his desk while Arjun sat on the bed and everything was exactly as it always was.

Except that Kiran had moved something. Quietly. Internally. Put it somewhere that wouldn't be visible.

Arjun looked at him once, midway through the evening, with a slight narrowing of his eyes.

"You okay?" he asked.

"Fine," Kiran said. Smooth. Even. The way he'd learned.

Arjun held his gaze for a moment.

Then: "Okay."

He didn't push.

Later, Kiran would understand that this was the moment — this was the specific evening — where a small fracture appeared in what they were building. Not a break. Not yet. But a hairline crack, the kind that spreads slowly when the structure is under pressure.

Tonight, he only knew that he had put something away.

And that putting it away had cost him something he wouldn't get back.

Chapter 23 — The Late Night That Changes Everything

Four days after the corridor.

Kiran had been careful. Precisely, deliberately careful — present enough that Arjun wouldn't notice a withdrawal, distant enough that his own interior could do whatever it needed to do without leaking. He was managing. He was fine.

And then Arjun showed up at 1 AM.

Not a knock. A message first: are you awake

Kiran looked at his phone in the dark. Suresh was asleep, breathing slow and even in the other bed. The campus outside was quiet — that specific 1 AM quiet that was different from all other quiet, heavier, more private.

Yes, he typed.

Thirty seconds later, a knock. The two-one pattern. Soft, so as not to wake Suresh.

Kiran got up. Opened the door.

Arjun was in the corridor in a t-shirt and track pants, clearly not having slept, hair slightly disheveled. He looked at Kiran in the low corridor light with an expression that was unusual for him: slightly lost. Like he'd come somewhere without being entirely sure why.

"Can I—" he started.

Kiran stepped back. Opened the door wider.

Arjun came in. They moved carefully around Suresh's sleeping form — Kiran to his bed, Arjun to the familiar spot at the edge of it, sitting the way he always sat, elbows on knees, looking at the floor.

The room was very dark. Only the faint corridor light under the door. Suresh's even breathing. The ceiling fan on low.

"What happened," Kiran said. Low. Not a question exactly. More like an opening.

Arjun was quiet for a moment.

"Do you ever feel like," he said, and stopped. Started again. "Like you're doing everything right. Everything you're supposed to. And it still feels—" He made a gesture. His hand in the dark, opening and closing. "Wrong. Like something is missing and you can't—" He stopped again.

Kiran looked at him. At the shape of him in the dark. At the way he was sitting — slightly collapsed, slightly less than his usual assembled self.

Arjun without his ease was a different thing entirely. More fragile. More real.

"Yes," Kiran said.

"How do you live with it?"

"You pay attention to what's actually there," Kiran said. "Instead of what's missing."

Arjun looked at him.

In the dark his eyes were very clear. The corridor light caught them — that particular quality of night light that made everything slightly more visible than it should be, slightly more honest.

"What's actually there," Arjun repeated. Like he was testing the weight of the phrase.

"Yes."

A long silence.

Arjun shifted on the bed. He lay back — slowly, like he was making a decision — and looked at the ceiling. Kiran stayed sitting, back against the headboard, watching the ceiling too.

They were close. They were always close, but 1 AM had a different geometry. The dark collapsed distances.

"Kiran," Arjun said.

"Hmm."

"I think I've been—" He stopped. Exhaled. "I've been not paying attention to something."

Kiran was very still.

"What something," he said. Carefully. The way you spoke around things that were fragile.

Arjun turned his head. He was looking at Kiran in the dark with that expression — the one from the photograph, the one Kiran had seen on the rooftop and in the library and in a hundred small unguarded moments — except more complete now. More arrived. Like something that had been assembling for months had finally found its form.

You,

he said.

One word.

Barely audible.

Kiran's heart did something seismic.

He looked at Arjun. At his face in the low light. At the openness of it, the vulnerability that Arjun wore so rarely and so carefully and was wearing now without armor, without management, just — exposed.

He's just my friend, said the voice in Kiran's chest. The careful voice. The protective one.

But the other voice — the one he'd been keeping quiet, the one that had been saying he's getting there, stay, wait, I'll be here — that voice was louder now.

"Arjun—" he started.

"I know," Arjun said. "I know I'm—" He pressed a hand briefly to his face. "I don't have the words yet. I just—" He dropped his hand. Looked at Kiran again. "I needed you to know I'm paying attention now. To what's actually there."

The room held the weight of that.

Suresh slept through it, peacefully oblivious.

Kiran sat in the dark with his heart doing things he didn't have architecture for, and looked at Arjun — this person who had rearranged his entire internal geography over eight months — and felt two things simultaneously:

I have been waiting for this.

And:

I heard what you said to Simran.

He didn't say either thing.

He said: "Okay."

Arjun looked at him. "Okay?"

"Okay," Kiran said. "I hear you."

Arjun nodded. Something in him settled — not fully, not completely, but enough. Like a weight shifted slightly.

He turned back to the ceiling.

After a few minutes his breathing slowed.

At 2 AM he was asleep.

Kiran sat in the dark for a long time.

I'm paying attention now. To what's actually there.

Four days ago: he's just my friend.

He held both things.

He did not yet know what to do with both things.

But he kept what Arjun had said — kept it carefully, like the photograph, like something that needed to be held until its meaning was clear.

He would figure it out.

- * -

He fell asleep at 3 AM still sitting up, and when he woke at seven Arjun was gone, and there was a note on the desk in Arjun's handwriting — just three words, on a torn piece of notebook paper:

thank you. sorry.

Kiran held the note.

He folded it. Put it in the same drawer as the photograph.

Chapter 24 — Almost Said

The note lived in the drawer for a week.

Arjun didn't mention the 1 AM visit. He showed up the next evening at seven as usual, two-one knock, sat in his spot, opened his notebook, and was — Arjun. Warm, present, easy. Like the conversation in the dark had been a door he'd opened and then, in the daylight, wasn't sure yet how far to go through.

Kiran matched him. Easy, present, warm. He was good at matching. He had been doing it for months.

But something had shifted in the space between them — a slight recalibration, like two instruments retuning to each other. The silences had a different quality now. Still comfortable, but charged in a new way. Like a room right before rain.

On Thursday Priya appeared at Kiran's door with chai and a look on her face that meant she had information.

"He asked about you," she said, settling on Suresh's empty bed with the ease of someone who had done this a hundred times.

"People ask about people."

"Arjun asked me — and I want you to hear the exact words — 'Is Kiran okay. Like actually okay. Not the okay he says when he means fine.'" She looked at him. "He knows your okay from your fine, Kiran."

Kiran was at his desk. He looked at his notebook.

"He's observant," he said.

"He's in love with you," Priya said. Matter of fact. Like she was reading a weather report.

"Priya—"

"I'm not asking you to do anything about it. I'm telling you what I see." She drank her chai. "What I also see is that something happened this week. You're carrying something."

He was quiet.

"I heard him tell someone he's just my friend," Kiran said.

Priya was still.

"When?"

"Earlier this week. I wasn't meant to hear it." He kept his voice even. "He wasn't wrong. He was just —"

"Protecting himself."

"Possibly." He looked at his notebook. "Or being honest."

"Or both," Priya said. "Scared people say the safe thing. Doesn't always mean the safe thing is the true thing." She set her chai down. "He came to you at 1 AM, Kiran. I know because Suresh told me because Suresh notices more than he lets on."

"He needed someone to talk to."

"He could have called ten people. He came to you."

Kiran said nothing.

Priya stood up. She picked up her chai. At the door she turned.

"You said you'd be here," she said quietly. "That's still true, right?"

He looked at her.

"Yes," he said.

She nodded. Left.

- * -

He sat at his desk for a long time after she left, the drawer with the note and the photograph three feet away from him, and thought about what it meant to be here. What it required. Whether being here meant waiting indefinitely or whether at some point being here required — saying something.

He picked up his pen.

He opened his notebook to a blank page.

He wrote: *Things I haven't said.*

Then he wrote, slowly, carefully, every true thing he hadn't said since October. The things from the roof, from the library, from the 1 AM dark. Not to show anyone. Just to see them outside of himself for once. Just to know what they looked like with shape.

He filled two pages.

He looked at what he'd written.

Then he closed the notebook, put it in the drawer with the photograph and the note, and went to the canteen for dinner.

- * -

Arjun was already there.

He looked up when Kiran walked in — that automatic shift of attention, the way he always found

Kiran in a room first — and moved his bag off the adjacent chair. The usual. Kiran sat. The usual.

They ate. They talked about something from today's lecture. Dilip said something that made the table laugh.

But once, just once, in the middle of it — Arjun looked at him. Not the social look, not the ambient warmth. The real look. The one from the dark. The one that said *I'm paying attention now.*

Kiran met it.

Two seconds.

Then they both looked away.

Almost said. Both of them.

Neither of them said it.

But both of them knew the other almost had.

*And that — that almost, acknowledged silently between them — was more than anything that had
been said so far.*

Chapter 25 — Kiran Pulls Back (First Time)

It was Kiran who blinked first.

Not dramatically. Not with confrontation or coldness. Just — a slight, deliberate stepping back from the edge. A recalibration of distance. The kind of thing only Arjun would notice, because only Arjun had been paying the specific quality of attention required to see it.

It started on a Sunday.

Arjun messaged at noon: **roof tonight?**

Kiran looked at the message. He thought about the roof. About the parapet wall and the city lights and what happened every time they sat up there in the dark close enough for shoulders to touch.

About the accumulation of almost and almost and almost that had been building in him since October and had no release valve and was becoming — too much. Just quietly, steadily too much.

Can't tonight, he typed. **Assignment.**

He didn't have an assignment.

He sat in his room and read his book and was fine. He was completely fine.

Arjun didn't reply for twenty minutes. Then: **okay.**

One word. No punctuation. Not the usual Arjun-texture of messages — the rambling, the jokes, the follow-up questions. Just: okay.

Kiran noticed this. He told himself he wasn't going to notice it and then noticed it anyway.

Monday: Arjun came at seven. The usual. But Kiran was at his desk when he arrived and stayed at his desk — not unusual, he often worked while Arjun used the bed — but the specific quality of his focus was different. More deliberate. He gave Arjun warmth but less access. Answered questions but didn't create openings. Was present without being available in the way he usually was.

Arjun felt it.

Kiran could see him feeling it — the slight recalibration in his own behavior, the way he was a fraction more careful with conversation, like he was stepping somewhere he wasn't sure of the ground.

By Wednesday the shift was visible enough that Suresh, who was not perceptive, looked between them twice during the study session.

- * -

On Thursday Arjun stayed after Suresh and Dilip left.

He sat on the edge of the bed. He looked at Kiran at the desk.

"What's happening," he said.

"Nothing." The automatic answer.

"Kiran." His voice had the quality it had at 1 AM — stripped back. Direct. "Don't do that."

Kiran turned in his chair. He looked at Arjun. At the slight tension in him — the way his hands were clasped between his knees, the set of his shoulders, the way he was watching Kiran with careful, intent eyes.

"I needed some space," Kiran said. Which was true.

"From me?"

"From—" He stopped. "From how things have been lately."

Arjun was quiet for a moment.

"Did I do something," he said.

He wasn't ready for everything. He hadn't been ready for everything for months and he kept arriving at the edge of it and the edge kept being closer.

"No," Kiran said. "You didn't do anything."

"Then why—"

"Arjun." He said it gently. Firmly. "I just needed a few days. That's all."

Arjun looked at him. He clearly didn't believe this was all. He was too perceptive not to know there was more underneath it. But he also — he recognized the boundary. He respected it, even if it frustrated him.

"Okay," he said. The same one word from the text. But spoken, it had more layers — resignation, worry, and underneath both of those something that sounded almost like fear.

He got up to leave.

At the door he stopped.

He turned around.

"Kiran."

Kiran looked at him.

"I don't like the distance," he said finally. "Whatever I did or didn't do. I don't like it."

Kiran's chest did something complicated.

"I know," he said quietly.

"Then—"

"Give me a few days, Arjun."

A long pause.

Arjun nodded. Once. The kind of nod that meant *I don't like this but I will respect it.*

He left.

- * -

The room was quiet.

Suresh looked up from his phone. Met Kiran's eyes. Looked back at his phone without saying anything.

For which Kiran was, in that moment, profoundly grateful.

He turned back to his desk.

He thought about what Arjun had said: *I don't like the distance.*

He thought about what Priya had said: *scared people say the safe thing.*

He thought about the note in the drawer: *thank you. sorry.*

He thought about a corridor outside room 207 and four words said through a thin door.

He thought about fingers between fingers on a parapet wall.

He thought about two pages of things he hadn't said.

Give me a few days.

He would figure it out.

He always figured things out, eventually.

He opened his notebook.

He didn't write anything.

He just sat there, in the quiet room, with the drawer three feet away and the evening settling into night outside his window, and let himself feel — without managing it, without directing it — the full and complicated weight of being in love with someone who was also, in their own way, figuring it out.

It was heavy.

It was also, underneath the weight, something that felt — despite everything, despite the corridor and the four words and the managed distances — unmistakably like hope.

He closed his notebook.

He went to sleep.

Tomorrow Arjun would knock at seven.

And Kiran would open the door.

Because he always did.

Because he'd said he'd be here.

And because — even now, even managing and hurting and stepping back — he meant it.

Chapter 26 — The Few Days Pass (Arjun Counts Them)

He counted them.

He would not have admitted this to anyone. He would barely admit it to himself. But the truth was that Arjun — who had never in his life counted anything that wasn't required for an exam — counted the days of Kiran's distance the way you counted things that mattered. Quietly, internally, with the specific attention of someone who had only recently understood the value of what they were measuring.

Day one: the missed roof night. He'd sat up there alone for an hour. The city had felt different without Kiran beside him. Flatter. Like a photograph instead of a place.

Day two: the study session where Kiran was present and unreachable simultaneously. Arjun had talked more than usual, filling space, and had hated himself slightly for it. He was not someone who filled space out of anxiety. He didn't recognize the version of himself that did.

Day three: he'd gone to the library at their usual time and sat in the adjacent chair and Kiran hadn't come. He'd stayed for two hours anyway. He'd told himself he was studying. He hadn't retained a single thing he'd read.

Day four: the conversation in the room. Give me a few days.

Day five: he woke up and checked his phone before he was fully conscious. One message from his mother. Nothing from Kiran. He put his phone face down and stared at the ceiling for ten minutes.

This was new.

Arjun was not someone who waited. He moved through the world at his own pace, and the world generally adjusted to him rather than the other way around. He did not sit with absence. He did not feel the specific hollow of a missing presence.

He felt it now.

He lay on his bed on day five and conducted, with some discomfort, an honest inventory.

When had this started. Not the noticing — he'd been noticing Kiran since the library, some part of him tracking that particular frequency without his permission. But the needing. When had noticing become needing.

He thought about the roof. I'll be here, Kiran had said. Fingers between fingers.

He thought about 1 AM in the dark room and the particular quality of Kiran's voice saying pay attention to what's actually there — and how he'd looked at Arjun after, with those careful honest eyes, and the word Arjun had said: you.

He'd said you.

He'd meant it completely. He just — hadn't known, until he said it, how completely he meant it. Words had a way of clarifying things. Speaking something out loud made it real in a way that thinking it didn't.

You.

He pressed the back of his hand to his mouth and looked at the ceiling.

He was in love with Kiran.

He sat with that.

He'd been circling it for months — getting close, stepping back, getting close again. He'd had the word in his periphery for weeks, trying it on, finding it fit but being unwilling to wear it fully. Now, on day five of Kiran's quiet deliberate distance, with the hollow of his absence sitting in Arjun's chest like a removed weight that had left its shape behind — now he wore it.

He was in love with Kiran.

The knowledge was terrifying and clarifying and complete.

He picked up his phone.

He put it back down.

Give me a few days, Kiran had said.

He would give him the days. He would count them. He would not send the message he was composing in his head — come back, I figured something out, I know what I should have said, I know what I want to say — because Kiran had asked for time and the least he could do, the absolute minimum, was give it.

- * -

Day six: he went to the canteen at the usual time and Kiran was there with Priya. Their eyes met across the room. Kiran looked at him steadily, without the careful blankness of the past few days. Something different — something considering.

Arjun sat at a separate table. He didn't push.

Kiran watched him not push.

- * -

Day seven: a message. From Kiran. At 6 PM.

Library?

Two seconds after reading it, Arjun was already putting his shoes on.

Coming, he typed.

He walked to the library faster than he normally walked anywhere.

Kiran was in their usual spot — his original chair, Arjun's adjacent one empty and waiting. He had his notebook open. He looked up when Arjun arrived and there it was: the warmth, the ease, the access he'd been holding back for a week.

Returned. Not all the way. Not yet. But enough.

Arjun sat down.

He didn't say anything. He opened his notebook.

Under the table, his foot found Kiran's.

Kiran didn't move away.

They studied in silence for two hours and Arjun thought: I love you. I'm going to tell you. Not yet — not today, not here — but I am. I'm going to say it properly. When I have the words. When you're ready. When I've earned it.

He looked at his notebook.

He wrote nothing useful for two hours.

He didn't mind at all.

Chapter 27 — Back — But Different

They were back.

That was the word Priya used when she observed them at lunch two days later: "You're back." Said to Kiran, quietly, while Arjun was at the vending machine. Kiran had nodded once. Yes. Back.

But Priya was perceptive enough to add: "Different though."

Different.

Kiran turned the word over. It was accurate. The texture of them had changed — not worse, not better, just shifted.

Like furniture rearranged in a room you knew well. The room was the same. The light fell differently.

What was different:

Arjun was more careful now. Not in a cautious way — in the way of someone who had understood the value of something and was handling it accordingly. He still showed up at seven. He still sat in his spot. But there was an attention in him now that had a different quality than before. Before it had been instinctive, ambient. Now it was deliberate. Chosen.

He asked questions he didn't used to ask. Not probing ones — just: how was your afternoon. Did you eat. What are you thinking about. Small checkings-in, offered without expectation of particular answers, just — offered.

- * -

And the physical things had shifted too.

The evening after the library — their first real evening together after the week of distance — they'd ended up on the roof. The usual time, the usual dark, the city below doing what it did. They'd sat in their spots on the parapet wall, and when Arjun's shoulder had found Kiran's, it had stayed there differently. More consciously. Like he'd chosen it instead of defaulted to it.

Kiran had felt the difference.

He'd also felt something else — the specific warmth of Arjun beside him in the April night, the end of the semester heat beginning to build, both of them in thin t-shirts, the warmth of his arm from shoulder to elbow a constant, deliberate presence.

Arjun had turned slightly toward him at some point — not fully, just angled — and Kiran had been aware of his breath, the sound of it, slow and even, close. The smell of him. Something warm and specific that Kiran had catalogued without meaning to over months of proximity.

"I missed this," Arjun said. To the city. Not quite to Kiran. Allowing Kiran to decide if he was meant to hear it.

To the city. Not quite to Kiran. Allowing Kiran to decide if he was meant to hear it.

"The roof?" Kiran said.

A pause.

"No," Arjun said.

Kiran looked at the city.

"I know," he said quietly.

Arjun turned his head. They were close enough that the movement brought his face near Kiran's — not inappropriately, just close, the way the parapet wall and natural drift had put them. Kiran could see the line of his jaw, the way the city lights caught the edge of his face, the particular expression he wore right now: open, slightly undefended, saying more than he was saying.

"Do you," Arjun said. Not a challenge. A real question.

"Yes," Kiran said.

They looked at each other for three seconds. Four.

Then Kiran looked back at the city.

But he didn't adjust the shoulder contact. He let it stay. And Arjun's arm pressed slightly more firmly against his — the smallest possible increase in pressure, barely perceptible — and that was that. An acknowledgment. An agreement.

Back. But different.

Different felt, Kiran thought carefully, like progress.

Different felt, Kiran thought carefully, like progress.

Chapter 28 — "My Kiran" — The Slip That Costs Him

It happened in the canteen on a Wednesday.

The lunch crowd at its peak, six of them at the usual table — Kiran, Arjun, Suresh, Dilip, Priya, and a girl from Priya's class named Tanvi who had been joining them occasionally. Loud. Normal. The kind of lunch that existed in a hundred colleges across the country simultaneously.

Tanvi had been talking about a friend of hers — some drama about a miscommunication, a missed plan, the usual social machinery. She'd mentioned, in the course of this story, that her friend had apparently done something inconsiderate without realizing it, and it had hurt someone.

"Some people just don't notice," Tanvi said. "Like they genuinely can't read what someone needs."

"Or they notice and don't act on it," Priya said. Pointed, in the way Priya was sometimes pointed without looking directly at anyone.

"Or they act on it in the wrong way," Suresh offered.

"Kiran would know," Arjun said.

He said it simply. Reflexively. Like a fact so settled he hadn't needed to think before stating it. He was looking at his food when he said it.

Everyone at the table looked at Kiran.

Then, because there was a half-second gap in the conversation, Arjun added — equally reflexively, equally without pausing — "My Kiran always knows what people need. It's annoying."

My Kiran.

The table went briefly, specifically quiet.

Not a dramatic quiet. Not a pointed quiet. The kind that lasted two seconds while everyone privately noted something and then, collectively, decided to continue as if it hadn't happened. Dilip blinked. Suresh very carefully looked at his food. Priya looked at the middle distance with an expression of enormous controlled satisfaction.

Kiran looked at Arjun.

Arjun had realized — half a second after he'd said it — what he'd said. Kiran could see the exact moment it registered: a slight change in his posture, a fractional stillness, and then the deliberate casualness of someone who had decided the best response to saying something revealing was to act like he hadn't.

He kept eating.

He did not look at Kiran.

His ears, Kiran noticed with a precision that felt almost unfair, had gone slightly red.

My Kiran.

Said in the middle of a crowded canteen table with six witnesses. Said like it was the most natural thing in the world. Said like it was a fact so embedded in his understanding of reality that it had bypassed the filter entirely.

Kiran looked at his food.

He was very warm.

He was very carefully constructing his expression into something neutral.

*He heard the word my and felt it the way you felt a piece of music that hit you somewhere structural
— not in the chest but underneath the chest, in the load-bearing parts.*

The conversation moved on. Tanvi continued her story. Suresh made a joke. The lunch proceeded.

But for the rest of it — Arjun didn't look at Kiran.

And Kiran didn't look at Arjun.

And Priya, across the table, was concentrating on her rice with the focused attention of someone who was extremely busy not smiling.

- * -

Afterward, walking back, the group dispersed gradually until it was just the two of them — which happened the way it always happened, everyone else peeling off toward their wings until Kiran and Arjun were the last ones, taking the longer path back without having discussed it.

Arjun walked beside him. Quiet. Not his usual comfortable quiet — something with more weight to it.

Kiran let it sit for a full minute.

Then: "You don't have to say anything," he said.

Arjun looked at him. Something flickering in his expression — relief and something else, something more complicated.

"I know I said—" he started.

"You don't have to," Kiran said again. Gently. "It's okay."

Arjun was quiet for a moment.

"Is it?" he asked. The real question underneath the question: **are we okay. Am I still okay. Did I just—**

Kiran looked at him.

The afternoon light was warm on his face. The campus around them was full of the usual post-lunch movement. In the middle of all of it, Arjun was looking at Kiran with his guard entirely down, with that expression that cost him something to wear, with the vulnerability of someone who had said a true thing accidentally and wasn't sure what it had cost.

"Yes," Kiran said.

He meant it.

Arjun exhaled.

They walked back.

At the hostel gate their paths split — different wings. Arjun tapped Kiran's shoulder once, lightly, the way he sometimes did as a goodbye.

His hand lingered for half a second longer than usual.

- * -

Then he was gone.

Kiran stood at the gate.

My Kiran, he thought.

He walked to his room, closed the door, and sat on his bed and pressed both palms flat against his own face and breathed.

Just breathed.

Chapter 29 — The Night the Heat Breaks

May arrived with the full force of a Hyderabad summer.

The kind of heat that made the air visible — shimmering off the roads, settling into the hostel corridors like something physical, turning nights that should have been cool into an extension of the day. Fans were useless above 11 PM. The rooftop, their rooftop, became bearable only after midnight when something that barely qualified as a breeze moved through.

They went up later now. Midnight instead of nine. And they dressed for the heat — which meant, this being a hostel in summer, minimal.

Kiran had noticed this approximately immediately and had been managing it approximately imperfectly.

Arjun in a t-shirt was something he had learned to navigate. Arjun in the thin worn cotton he wore to sleep in, or the loose athletic shorts from the hostel gym, or — as on this particular night — no t-shirt at all because he'd come directly from the bathroom to the roof because the bathroom had cool water and the corridor had not —

This was new.

"Sorry," Arjun said, appearing at the roof door looking damp and apologetic and entirely unaware of being a problem. "Too hot to go back for a shirt."

Kiran looked at him for exactly two seconds. Then at the city.

"Fine," he said. His voice came out completely normal. He was proud of this.

Arjun sat beside him on the parapet wall.

The city was doing its late-night version — quieter, the lights lower, the sounds reduced to the occasional far-off horn and the insects and the hum of a thousand air conditioners below. The breeze, such as it was, moved through irregularly, warm but better than nothing.

Kiran was acutely aware of the person beside him.

Arjun's shoulder against his was different without a layer of cotton between them. Warm skin against the thin fabric of Kiran's own t-shirt — the temperature of him, the specific living warmth of another person in the dark. Kiran kept his eyes on the city and was excruciatingly aware of every point of contact.

"Better up here," Arjun said. He rolled his shoulders, tilted his head back slightly, letting the intermittent breeze do what it could. In the low ambient light of the city sky his face was angled upward, eyes half-closed. He looked —

Kiran looked at the city.

"Yes," he said.

"Can't sleep in that room," Arjun said. "It's like being inside an oven."

"I know."

"Your side of the hostel is worse. You're south-facing." He looked at Kiran now. Noticing things, as always, about Kiran's environment, Kiran's comfort. "You should get a desk fan."

"I have a desk fan."

"A better one." His shoulder pressed slightly more into Kiran's. Not purposeful, just — settling. Getting comfortable. "I'll come look at what they have in the market."

"You don't have to—"

"I want to." Simple. Clear. Said with the same directness that *my Kiran* had been said with, the register of things that bypassed his filter.

Kiran looked at the city.

The breeze came through again. It moved Arjun's damp hair slightly. He made a small satisfied sound at the back of his throat, a barely-there sound, the kind you made when something felt good and you weren't performing the feeling for anyone.

Kiran was going to have to work very hard for the next several weeks.

"Hey," Arjun said.

"Hmm."

"What are you thinking."

The question. The one he always asked. Kiran had noticed it was exclusively his question — Arjun asked it to no one else. He'd checked, over months, with the careful thoroughness of someone who needed to know whether a thing was particular or general. It was particular.

"I'm thinking," Kiran said carefully, "that the heat makes it harder to be in your own head."

Arjun considered this. "Good or bad."

"Both."

A pause.

"Yeah," Arjun said.

- * -

He shifted — and then, with the directness that had been increasing in him since day five of the distance week, since the slip in the canteen, since something had apparently been decided in him that he was still arriving at in pieces — he turned slightly and lay his head on Kiran's shoulder.

Not tentative. Deliberate.

Warm bare shoulder against Kiran's neck. The weight of his head. His hair still slightly damp from the bathroom.

Kiran stopped breathing for a full second.

Then he breathed.

He did not move.

He did not lean away. He did not make it smaller.

He sat there on the parapet wall at midnight in the Hyderabad summer with Arjun's head on his shoulder and the city lights below them and the warm irregular breeze and the sound of both of them breathing and let it be what it was.

Let it be what it is,* he thought. *Just for tonight. Just this.

Arjun's eyes were closed.

His hand, resting on the parapet beside Kiran's, moved — slow, unhurried — until his fingers were over Kiran's.

Not between, this time. Over.

Covering.

His thumb moved once — a slow deliberate stroke across Kiran's knuckles. Once, and then settling. His hand warm and heavy over Kiran's in the summer dark.

Neither of them spoke.

The city hummed below them.

At some point a dog barked somewhere far away, was answered by another, and then the night went back to its hum. A bike engine. A door somewhere below.

Kiran looked at the city and felt the weight of Arjun's head and the warmth of his hand and the specific quality of this silence — the best kind, the kind that meant nothing was wrong, the kind that held something very large very gently.

He closed his eyes for a moment.

Just a moment.

This,* he thought. *This is what I meant. About what's actually there.

He opened his eyes.

The city. The heat. Arjun's head on his shoulder, his breathing evening out toward something like

peace.

I love you,* Kiran thought. For the first time, he let himself think it fully, without the management, without the careful rationing. Just completely. *I love you and I don't know what you are yet to me and I don't know what I am yet to you but I'm here. I'm here.

- * -

They stayed there until 2 AM.

Neither of them mentioned it the next day.

But something had crossed a threshold.

Both of them knew it.

Chapter 30 — Kiran Makes A Decision

He told Priya at seven in the morning, which was testament to how much it was occupying him because Kiran did not voluntarily communicate before 8 AM.

He knocked on her hostel door — she was in the girls' wing, a five-minute walk — and when she opened it in her sleep clothes looking understandably confused, he said: "I need to tell you something."

She stepped back. Let him in. Made tea on her hotplate without asking whether he wanted any.

He sat on her desk chair. She sat cross-legged on her bed with her chai. Outside her window the campus was barely awake — the groundskeeper's cart, a distant lecture bell for the early section.

"Something happened," he said.

He told her. Not everything — not the two pages in the notebook, not the full interior inventory — but enough. The roof last night. Arjun's head on his shoulder. The hand. The two hours.

Priya listened. She wrapped both hands around her cup. She did not interrupt.

When he finished she was quiet for a moment.

Then: "What are you going to do."

"I don't know," he said. "That's the problem."

"What are your options."

He'd been thinking about this since 2 AM, when he'd gone back to his room and lain awake in the heat with the ceiling fan providing its inadequate comfort. He'd been systematic about it, the way he was systematic about things that required decisions.

"Option one," he said. "Keep going as we are. Let it build at whatever pace it's building. Wait for him to arrive at whatever he's arriving at."

"And the problem with that."

"I overhear another phone call," Kiran said simply. "Or someone else does something. Or he goes somewhere for a summer internship and the distance resets things and he comes back different. Waiting has a cost. I've been paying it. It's fine. But it has a cost."

Priya nodded. "Option two."

"I say something." He looked at his tea. "I tell him. What it is. What it's been. Give him the full information."

"And the problem with that."

"He's not there yet." He said it without bitterness. Just factually. "He's getting there — I believe

that, I think that's true — but he's not there. And if I say it before he arrives, I put the weight of my feeling onto whatever he's still figuring out. That's — I don't want to do that to him."

Priya was quiet.

"And option three?" she asked. Because she knew him. She knew there was a three.

He looked at the window. The campus in early morning light.

"I create one clear moment," he said. "Not a confession. Not a demand. Just — a moment where it's possible. Where if he wants to close the distance, it's clear that he can. And then I let it be his choice."

Priya looked at him for a long moment.

"That's terrifying," she said.

"Yes."

"That's also the right one," she said.

He looked at her.

She shrugged. "You've been creating moments for him for nine months. But they've all been — available from a distance. Warm but not clear. He doesn't know if there's a door or just a wall that looks like one." She held his gaze. "Make it a door. A visible one. And then step back and let him decide."

Kiran thought about this.

He thought about Arjun counting days during the distance week — which he hadn't known for certain but had suspected, the way you suspected things about people you knew as well as he knew Arjun. He thought about **my Kiran** said reflexively in the canteen. He thought about a head on his shoulder at midnight and a hand covering his.

He's getting there.

"Okay," Kiran said.

"Okay you'll do it?"

"Okay I'll do it."

Priya smiled. The real one, the one she saved for things that genuinely mattered. "Good."

He stood. Picked up his tea. Drank the last of it.

"Priya."

"Hmm."

"If this goes badly—"

"It won't."

"But if it does—"

"Then you'll survive it," she said. "Because you've survived everything else. And also—" she pointed at him — "it won't."

- * -

He walked back to his hostel in the early morning, the campus slowly waking around him. The groundskeeper. The canteen staff opening the shutters. A few early risers, heads down, moving toward the academic block.

He had a plan.

Not a grand gesture plan. Not a declaration plan. Kiran's version of a plan — quiet, clear, specific. One moment. One visible door.

He had — he counted quickly — three weeks left of the semester.

He had time.

He would choose the moment when it was right and then he would let it be what it was and Arjun would see the door and he would walk through it or he wouldn't and either way Kiran would finally know.

He went to breakfast.

He was terrified.

He was also, underneath the terror, the most certain he'd been about anything in a very long time.

- * -

He sat in the canteen. He ordered idli and sambar. He looked at his phone.

A message. From Arjun. Sent at 7:03 AM.

good morning

Just that.

Kiran looked at the message.

He thought about a head on his shoulder and a hand over his and two hours of the best silence he'd ever sat in.

Good morning, he typed back.

Then, after a second, he added — the first extra thing, the first small step toward the visible door:

Last night was good.

He put his phone down.

Sixty seconds later, his phone buzzed.

yeah, Arjun had written.

And then, after five seconds:

it really was.

Kiran picked up his idli.

He was smiling.

He was going to do this.

Chapter 31 — The Moment Kiran Plans

He didn't plan it the way Arjun would have planned it.

Arjun, Kiran had observed over nine months, operated on instinct — moved toward things that felt right and trusted that the movement itself would clarify the direction. It was how he studied, how he socialized, how he existed in the world. Instinct first, understanding after.

Kiran was the opposite. He needed to see the shape of something before he moved toward it. He needed, at minimum, to know where the edges were.

So he planned.

Not a script — he was not someone who could script a real moment, and anything scripted would feel wrong, would ring false in the specific way that Arjun, who could read Kiran better than anyone, would immediately hear. Just the conditions. Just: **if these things are true, then this moment is possible.**

Conditions:

They needed to be alone. Actually alone — not the library where anyone could walk in, not the canteen, not the study group. Their roof, after midnight, which had become the most private space either of them had. The roof had precedent. The roof had established itself as the place where real things were said and real silences were sat in and real contact happened.

He needed to have said something first. Something small, something true, something that opened the door a crack further than it currently was. Not a declaration — he'd been clear with Priya about that. Just a visible door. But a door required a frame, and a frame required something said.

And then he would — he paused on this part, lying on his bed in the heat of May, staring at the ceiling.

He would let Arjun see that he could come through.

That was the whole plan. Let him see the door. Step back. Let it be his choice.

Simple.

Terrifying.

He spent three days finding the right small true thing to say. He considered and rejected many options. Too much — too little — too pointed — too vague. On the third day he had it. Seven words. He tried them in the dark and they felt right. They were true, they were clear, and they left room for Arjun to decide what to do with them.

Seven words.

He kept them in his pocket like the photograph.

- * -

Two days later, on a Friday evening at the end of the second-to-last week of semester, Arjun messaged at 10 PM: *roof?*

Kiran looked at the message.

Yes, he typed. *Give me ten minutes.*

He sat on the edge of his bed. Suresh was visiting his girlfriend's hostel — another carefully negotiated visit. The room was empty. The campus outside was doing its Friday end-of-week unwinding, the sounds of it carrying in through the window.

He pressed both hands flat on his knees.

*He thought about nine months. The library seat. The rain. The rooftop in December. Fingers between fingers. A head on his shoulder. *My Kiran.* Midnight and the city lights and the warmth of a hand over his knuckles in the dark.*

He thought about *give me a few days* and the note in the drawer and the photograph.

He thought about Arjun on day five, lying in his own room, and whatever inventory he'd done.

He thought about: *I'm getting there.*

Okay, Kiran thought.

- * -

He stood up.

He went to the roof.

Chapter 33 — The Almost Kiss — First Attempt

The right moment came at 12:43 AM.

He knew this because he'd looked at his phone two minutes earlier — not for any reason, just the unconscious time-checking of someone who was very aware of how long they'd been on a roof managing their own courage.

Suresh's voice note had been dealt with. The conversation had done another full loop and come back to quiet. The city below was at its lowest frequency — 1 AM approaching, the sounds reduced to minimum. The breeze had come in about twenty minutes ago and hadn't left, which meant it was genuinely cooler now, the heat of the day finally conceding.

Arjun had his eyes closed.

Not sleeping — just resting, head tilted back slightly, face turned up toward the open sky. Completely relaxed. Completely himself in the specific way he was only on this rooftop, in these hours, with Kiran.

Kiran looked at him.

Not carefully, not managed. Just looked. Allowed himself the full clear-eyed honesty of it.

The line of his jaw in the low light. The rise and fall of his chest, slow and even. His hands resting on the parapet — the right one three inches from Kiran's left. His expression completely unguarded, every layer of social performance dissolved, just: the person underneath all of it. Quiet. Real.

I love you, Kiran thought. Completely. Without management.

He looked at the three inches between their hands.

"Arjun," he said.

Arjun opened his eyes. Turned his head. Not slowly — fully present, immediately, the way he always was when Kiran said his name in that particular register. His eyes found Kiran's directly.

"Yeah," he said.

Kiran held his gaze.

The seven words. He'd carried them for five days. He said them now — quietly, evenly, with no decoration:

I don't want just this summer.

Silence.

Not the comfortable kind. A different kind — the kind that had electricity in it. The kind where something had been put into the air and was now hanging there, waiting for someone to decide

what to do with it.

Arjun was very still.

He was looking at Kiran with an expression that was doing several things simultaneously — processing, understanding, arriving somewhere. The colour of his eyes in the low light. The specific quality of his attention: absolute, complete.

"What do you mean," he said. Low. He knew what Kiran meant. He was asking anyway, the way you asked when you needed to hear the thing fully.

"I mean," Kiran said, "that in three weeks the semester ends. And things change. They always change after summers." He held Arjun's gaze. "I don't want this — what we are — to be something that changes. I don't want to lose it to distance or time or things that don't get said."

Arjun was quiet.

"That's what I mean," Kiran said.

And then he stopped. Because that was the door. That was the frame. He'd said the true thing, the clear thing, and now it was —

Arjun moved.

Not all at once. Slowly — the way he'd laid his head on Kiran's shoulder, the way he'd put his hand over Kiran's knuckles. Deliberate. Chosen. His hand closed over Kiran's on the parapet wall, properly, warm and firm, the way it had been learning to.

And then he turned toward Kiran — fully, shifting his whole body — and raised his free hand, and put it against the side of Kiran's face.

His palm against Kiran's jaw.

Warm. Still. His thumb near Kiran's cheekbone.

Kiran stopped breathing.

Arjun was close. Not the ambient closeness of shared space — close in the specific way that required a decision. His face a few inches from Kiran's, turned toward him, his eyes moving between Kiran's eyes and his mouth with the careful attention of someone reading something important.

"Kiran," he said. Very quietly.

"Yes," Kiran said. Just as quiet. He didn't know exactly what he was saying yes to. He meant it for everything.

Arjun's thumb moved — the smallest motion, just a degree, against Kiran's cheekbone. His forehead dropped forward, slowly, until it rested against Kiran's.

Foreheads together.

Eyes closed — both of them, simultaneously, the way you closed your eyes when something was almost too much to stay open for.

Kiran could feel Arjun's breath. The warmth of it. The slight unsteadiness of it — Arjun, who was always steady, slightly unsteady right now.

The city below them. The breeze. The 1 AM quiet.

The distance between them was nothing. A decision. Half an inch.

Arjun's nose brushed Kiran's — the lightest contact, barely there, the edge of a touch, and Kiran felt it like a current running from that point through his entire body —

- * -

The roof door opened.

Two second-year boys, laughing about something, half-drunk on the particular freedom of a Friday night. They came through the door and stopped when they saw the two figures at the parapet wall, registered the presence of other people, and the taller one said "oh, sorry, didn't think anyone was up here—"

Arjun had pulled back.

Not dramatically. Not guiltily. Just — the distance was there again, suddenly, where it hadn't been. His hand off Kiran's face. His forehead no longer against Kiran's. Two people sitting at a parapet wall instead of — instead of whatever they'd been about to be.

"It's fine," Arjun said. His voice completely even. Completely managed. The social version, the easy-in-any-situation version.

Kiran looked at the city.

He breathed.

The two boys settled somewhere at the other end of the roof, their conversation resuming. The interruption continuing.

Kiran's hands were in his lap. His right hand — the one Arjun had been holding — felt the absence of the contact like a specific shape.

He did not look at Arjun.

Arjun did not look at him.

The city was exactly the same as it had always been.

Chapter 34 — Interrupted

They stayed on the roof for twenty more minutes.

They were not alone. The two boys were still there — oblivious, laughing, having a completely ordinary conversation about completely ordinary things with absolutely no idea what they'd walked into. Kiran thought distantly that he had no strong feelings about them as people and a very specific feeling about their timing.

Arjun had his arms folded. He was looking at the city. His jaw was not tight — he'd relaxed back into his composure with the ease of someone practiced at it — but there was something contained in him. Something that had been moving and had been stopped and was now sitting very still.

Kiran recognized that stillness. He had his own version of it.

At 1:10 AM, Arjun said — quietly, so the two boys wouldn't hear — "We should sleep."

"Yes," Kiran said.

They went back inside.

- * -

Down the stairs. The corridor junction. Kiran's wing left, Arjun's wing right.

They stopped.

This was the moment — Kiran knew it, felt it, the whole weight of the interrupted roof coming to rest here at the corridor junction at 1 AM. Whatever hadn't been finished upstairs was still hanging between them, unresolved, waiting.

Arjun looked at him.

His expression was — complex.

Something that had been opened and hadn't closed properly. Like a door in wind.

"Kiran—"

"It's okay," Kiran said.

"I wasn't going to say it wasn't."

"I know."

A pause. Arjun looked at him with those eyes that Kiran had been reading for nine months and still sometimes couldn't fully translate.

"What you said," Arjun said. "On the roof."

"Yes."

"I heard it."

"I know you did."

"I just—" He stopped. His hand came up and pressed briefly to the back of his own neck — a gesture Kiran associated with Arjun being frustrated with his own inability to say something. "I need—"

"You don't have to say anything right now," Kiran said. Gently. Meaning it. "I said what I said. It doesn't need a response tonight."

Arjun looked at him.

"You're very calm about this," he said.

"I've had nine months of practice," Kiran said.

A beat.

Something shifted in Arjun's expression — a recognition, a landing. *Nine months.* The weight of it registered. Kiran watched it register, watched Arjun understand fully, maybe for the first time, the length and shape of what Kiran had been carrying.

His hand came out.

He held Kiran's wrist — gently, the way he had at the hostel gate months ago, two fingers around bone. But this time he didn't let go after a second. He held it for the length of a breath. Then two.

His thumb pressed once, lightly, against Kiran's pulse point.

Then he released.

"Goodnight, Kiran," he said. His voice did the thing it did sometimes — slightly rougher than usual, slightly unguarded.

"Goodnight," Kiran said.

- * -

Arjun turned. Walked toward his wing.

At the first corner he stopped. Turned back.

Looked at Kiran, who hadn't moved yet.

He opened his mouth. Closed it. Something trying to arrive that hadn't found its words yet.

Then — quietly, almost too quiet to hear: "Don't lose it."

"What?" Kiran said.

"The patience you have." His eyes were direct. "Don't lose it. I'm — I'm almost there."

Kiran held his gaze.

"I know," he said.

Arjun nodded. Once.

He turned the corner. He was gone.

- * -

Kiran stood at the junction.

His wrist still felt the pressure of two fingers. His cheekbone still held the ghost warmth of a palm.
His forehead remembered.

Don't lose it. I'm almost there.

He went to his room. He lay down in the heat. The fan turned.

He was not going to lose it.

He'd waited nine months.

He could wait a little longer.

He closed his eyes.

He was smiling.

Chapter 35 — What Gets Said Instead

The next morning was Saturday.

No lectures. The campus in its weekend mode — slower, quieter, the pressure of the week released. Kiran woke at seven, which was late for him but still early by hostel standards, and lay in the morning light of his room listening to Suresh breathe through the last of his sleep.

He thought about last night.

Not with anxiety — with a kind of clear-eyed calm that had arrived sometime in the night and hadn't left. He'd said the true thing. The door was visible. Arjun had held his wrist and said *don't lose it, I'm almost there.* These were facts. He arranged them in order and looked at them and found them, overall, better than they might have been.

His phone was on the mattress beside him. He looked at it.

No message. It was 7 AM. This was fine.

He got up. He showered. He dressed. He was making tea on the hotplate when his phone buzzed.

are you awake

He looked at the message for a second. Smiled. Typed:

Yes. Making tea.

can i come

He looked at the message.

Yes.

The knock came four minutes later. The two-one pattern. He opened the door.

Arjun.

He was in the t-shirt and track pants of someone who hadn't gone back to sleep after 1 AM — or had slept briefly and badly and woken early. His hair was slightly disheveled. He looked like he'd been thinking for several hours and had arrived somewhere and wanted to tell someone about it.

He came in. He sat in his spot on the bed. He looked at Kiran, who had sat back in his desk chair with his tea, waiting.

"I've been awake since 3," Arjun said.

"I thought so."

"I couldn't — there was too much. In my head." He pressed his palms to his knees, looked at the floor, looked up. "Can I say something."

"Yes," Kiran said.

Arjun took a breath.

"I don't know how to do this correctly," he said. "I want you to know that. I'm not — I'm not someone who does this. Feelings. The saying of them. I move through things quickly and I trust my instincts and I've never—" He stopped. "With you it's different. Everything is slower and more — I notice everything. I overthink things I've never overthought. I came to your room at 1 AM because I couldn't figure out why my apartment felt wrong and then I got there and it was—" He stopped again.

"It was what," Kiran said. Quietly.

"It was right." He met Kiran's eyes. "Being where you are is right. I don't know when that started. I don't know how it got to be — what it is. But I know that when you pulled back for those days I felt it like something physical. And I know that last night on the roof when I had my hand on your face I wasn't confused about what I wanted. I wasn't uncertain. I was just—" He exhaled. "I was just terrified."

Suresh slept on.

The morning light was coming through the window at its early angle, the specific warmth of it that arrived before the day became hot. The tea was in Kiran's hands, forgotten. He was looking at Arjun — at the effort of him, the visible effort of someone doing something that didn't come naturally with someone he couldn't afford to do it wrong with.

"Terrified of what," Kiran said.

"That I'd say it wrong. That I'd—" He stopped. "That it would cost me you. That I'd handle it badly, the way I handle things sometimes, and you'd—" He looked at Kiran with those clear direct eyes.

"You're the person I most don't want to handle badly, Kiran. That's — I realized that. That's a significant thing."

Kiran set his tea down.

He looked at Arjun.

At this person — messy-haired in the morning light, sitting on the edge of his bed like he had a hundred times, doing something that cost him and doing it anyway because he'd been awake since 3 AM and had needed to say it — and he thought:

Here is the door.

Here he is, standing in it.

- * -

He stood up from his desk chair.

He crossed the small distance between desk and bed — four steps, five — and sat on the bed beside Arjun. Not the headboard, not the foot. Beside him, directly, close enough that their arms were touching.

Arjun looked at him.

"You haven't handled me badly," Kiran said. "Not once."

"I said you were just—"

"I know what you said." He held Arjun's gaze. "I know why you said it. And I know it's not what you meant."

Arjun was still. Looking at Kiran with an expression that was doing that thing again — the open, undefended, arriving thing. Every layer gone.

"No," he said quietly. "It's not what I meant."

"I know."

Silence.

Not complicated. Not charged. Clean.

Arjun's hand found Kiran's on the mattress between them — not over it, not beside it. He turned Kiran's hand over gently, palm up, and held it properly. Properly, in the full daylight, with Suresh sleeping three feet away and the morning coming through the window and nowhere to be, nothing to perform, just the two of them and the plain clear truth of it.

"What I meant," Arjun said, "is this."

He looked down at their joined hands. Then up at Kiran.

"I meant this," he said. "I meant — whatever this is, all of it, since the library, the roof, all of it. I meant you." His voice, when he said the last word, was the 1 AM version — rougher, unguarded, real. "I meant you."

Kiran breathed.

I meant you.

He thought about nine months. Two pages in a notebook. The photograph in the drawer. *I'll be here.* Three weeks of distance and seven words and a plan made at seven in the morning at Priya's door.

He thought about patience. About *I'm almost there.* About *don't lose it.*

He looked at Arjun.

"Okay," he said.

"Okay?" Arjun let out a breath that was almost a laugh — the undone kind, the relief kind.

"Okay," Kiran said again. Warm. Certain. "I meant you too. Since — for a long time. I meant you too."

Arjun looked at him for a moment.

Then he dropped his head forward — slowly, the way he did everything intentional — and rested it against Kiran's shoulder. Not the 1 AM version, not the midnight roof version. The morning version. Still, deliberate, close.

Kiran turned his head slightly. His cheek against the top of Arjun's head.

Their hands still joined on the mattress between them.

"We're doing this then," Arjun said. Into his shoulder.

"Yes," Kiran said. "We're doing this."

A pause.

"Good," Arjun said.

- * -

Suresh slept on, blissfully, through all of it.

Outside the window the campus was waking up. Saturday sounds — music from somewhere, a water fight in the courtyard below, someone calling someone else's name across the quad. The ordinary machinery of a hostel morning.

In the room, in the morning light, two people sat on the edge of a bed with their hands joined and their heads together and the full and complicated weight of nine months settling into something that had, finally, a name.

Not *just* anything.

Not the thing you said to make someone feel safe.

Something real. Something chosen. Something that had been building in the specific quality of every silence and every rooftop and every orange cold drink placed without thinking, since a Thursday evening in a library when one person had sat in another person's chair.

I meant you.

The morning continued.

Neither of them moved.

Chapter 36 — After (The Morning After The Morning)

Suresh woke at nine.

He blinked at the ceiling. Turned his head. Registered the following, in order: Kiran at his desk, which was normal. Arjun on Kiran's bed, which was not unusual. The specific quality of the silence in the room, which was — different.

He looked at Kiran.

Kiran looked back at him with an expression of perfect composure.

Suresh looked at Arjun, who was lying back against the headboard scrolling his phone with one ankle crossed over his knee, the picture of casualness except for the very slight upward curve at the corner of his mouth that he was not entirely managing to suppress.

Suresh looked at the ceiling.

"Okay," he said, to no one in particular.

"Good morning," Kiran said.

"Mm," Suresh said. He sat up. He reached for his phone. He appeared to decide, wisely, that whatever had happened in this room while he was sleeping was not something he was going to ask about directly. "Breakfast?" he said.

"Yes," Arjun said.

"Yes," Kiran said.

They went to breakfast.

- * -

Walking across the quad in the Saturday morning — Suresh slightly ahead, Kiran and Arjun side by side behind him — Arjun's hand found Kiran's briefly. Not holding, just — fingers brushing fingers, the lightest contact, testing something in the daylight that had been tested in the dark on a rooftop and found solid.

Kiran felt the brush of it.

He didn't move his hand away.

Arjun's fingers curled slightly — the beginning of holding, loose, tentative, asking.

Kiran turned his hand over.

Their fingers laced together for approximately ten seconds, walking across the Saturday morning quad, the campus going about its ordinary business around them, the sunlight doing what sunlight did, everything regular and extraordinary simultaneously.

Then Suresh turned to say something about the canteen menu and they separated — naturally, without drama — and Kiran looked at his own hand and thought:

Oh.

So that's what that feels like.

Not the dark rooftop. Not the managed silence. The open morning, the ordinary quad, the deliberate choice of it.

That's what that felt like.

He ate his breakfast. He talked to Suresh about the weekend plan. He listened to Arjun argue about something with a friend from the adjacent table who had appeared with strong opinions about the upcoming cricket match.

Normal. Saturday. Ordinary.

Except every few minutes Arjun looked at him — not the long looks, not the loaded ones, just a glance, light and easy and new — and Kiran looked back and something passed between them that was warmer than it had been yesterday.

Something that had a name now.

- * -

After breakfast Suresh disappeared to his girlfriend's again — his planning had apparently extended to the whole weekend — and they were alone in the room, which felt different now that something had shifted. Not awkward. Just — aware. Like the room itself knew something had changed.

Arjun sat on the bed. Kiran at his desk. The usual arrangement.

"So," Arjun said.

"So," Kiran said.

A pause that held laughter underneath it — not quite surfacing, just there, the lightness of something that had been heavy for so long being put down.

"I don't know how to do this," Arjun said. He said it easily. Without the weight of last night's confession — that had been said, that had been given, and what remained was simpler. "I've never —" He gestured vaguely. "I mean. You know."

"I know," Kiran said.

"Are you going to help me or are you going to watch me figure it out?"

"Probably both," Kiran said. "Depending on the situation."

Arjun looked at him. The smile again — the real one, left-sided, completely unguarded. "That's fair."

He leaned back on his hands.

"Tell me something," he said.

"What."

"The first time. When did you—" He paused. "When did you know."

Kiran considered this. He looked at the window, the morning light. He thought about October. The amphitheater. A dark path behind the canteen, walking home alone after the fest, saying a name to himself for the first time.

"The festival," he said. "Second semester. You were on stage and you looked up and found me across the whole crowd." He looked at Arjun. "That was when I knew."

Arjun was quiet for a moment.

"I remember that," he said. Slightly wonder in his voice. "I remember looking for you specifically. I don't know why. I just—" He shook his head slightly. "I didn't understand it then."

"I know you didn't."

"When did you know that I didn't understand it?"

"October," Kiran said. "Same night."

Arjun absorbed this. "You've been—"

"Managing," Kiran said. "Yes."

Arjun looked at him with an expression that was several things at once — admiration, guilt, something softer underneath both. "I'm sorry it took so long," he said.

"Don't apologize," Kiran said. "You arrived when you were ready. That matters more than the timing."

Arjun looked at him steadily. "You really believe that."

"Yes."

"How," he said. Genuine. Asking for the mechanism of it.

Kiran thought about this.

"Because I know you," he said finally. "I've been paying attention for nine months. You're not someone who does things halfway once you understand them. The waiting was just you getting there." He held Arjun's gaze. "And you're here now."

Arjun was very still.

Then he stood up from the bed.

He crossed to Kiran's desk — three steps — and crouched down in front of his chair so they were level, face to face, close. His elbows on his knees. His eyes directly on Kiran's.

"I'm here," he said.

"I know," Kiran said.

"I'm going to be here," Arjun said. Like a promise being made deliberately. Like he understood the weight of the word here in the specific language of what they were. "Not just today."

Kiran looked at him.

At his face, level with his, in the morning light.

"Okay," Kiran said.

"Okay," Arjun repeated. And then the smile — the completely undone version, the one that changed his whole face. "Okay."

He stood. He ruffled Kiran's hair — unexpected, light, the first new gesture in this new version of them — and went back to the bed.

Kiran looked at his desk and pressed his hand briefly to the top of his own head where Arjun's hand had been.

He opened his notebook.

He was not going to get any studying done today.

He was completely fine with this.

Chapter 37 — Telling Priya

He didn't tell her.

She found out in the way Priya found out most things — by looking at Kiran for approximately four seconds at lunch on Sunday and reading everything from his face.

"Oh," she said.

Kiran looked at his food. "What."

"*Oh,*" she said again. Differently this time — the full weight of it, the satisfaction of being correct about something she'd been correct about for seven months.

"Priya—"

"Don't. Let me have this." She put her chai down. She looked at him with bright eyes. "Tell me everything."

He told her — more than he'd told anyone, more than he'd said out loud, because Priya had earned it and because saying it made it more real and real was something he was still adjusting to. He told her about the seven words and the roof and the interrupted almost and the corridor and *don't lose it I'm almost there* and the Saturday morning and *I meant you* and the hand on the quad in the ordinary daylight.

Priya listened to all of it without interrupting, which was unusual for her and meant she understood the weight of it.

When he finished she was quiet for a moment.

Then: "He said *I meant you.*"

"Yes."

"In those words."

"In those words."

She looked at the middle distance. "I knew," she said. "I knew since February at least. Possibly January." She looked at him. "Do you know how difficult it has been not to just—"

"I know."

"—lock you both in a room and—"

"Priya."

"I'm just saying the temptation existed." She picked up her chai. She looked at him over the rim with a warm directness that was entirely her. "You're happy."

It wasn't a question.

"Yes," Kiran said.

"Good." Simply. Completely. "You're allowed to be, you know. You've been so careful about only taking what was offered and not wanting more than was available and — you're allowed to just have the thing, Kiran. Without managing it."

You're allowed to just have the thing, Kiran. Without managing it.

He looked at his food.

"I'm working on that," he said.

"Work faster," she said.

He smiled.

"Tell Arjun he took too long," she added. "From me."

"I will not tell him that."

"Tell him I said congratulations then."

"I'll consider it."

She reached across the table and put her hand over his briefly — not a long gesture, not sentimental, just: *I see you and I'm glad.* Then she went back to her chai.

"What happens in third year," she said. Back to practical, because Priya's love language was practicality. "You're Mechanical and CSE. Still different schedules."

"I know."

"Same hostel block though."

"Yes."

"And summer?"

"Two weeks," he said. "He goes to Delhi. I go to Vizag."

"Two weeks is manageable." She thought. "Then what."

"Then," Kiran said, "I think we figure it out."

She looked at him.

"You think you figure it out," she repeated.

"Yes."

"That's very calm of you."

"I have been," Kiran said, "practicing calm for approximately nine months."

I have been practicing calm for approximately nine months.

Priya's expression flickered — amusement, warmth, something that recognized the cost of that.
"Fair," she said quietly.

They finished lunch.

- * -

Walking back, she said: "Suresh knows, by the way."

"I know he knows."

"He told Dilip."

Kiran stopped walking. "He told—"

"Dilip's exact words, apparently, were: *I thought something was going on.*" She kept walking.
"You remember the inseparable comment."

Kiran resumed walking. "Dilip."

"Called it in November," she said cheerfully. "He's very pleased with himself."

Kiran thought about this for a moment.

"Is the whole hostel—"

"Not yet," Priya said. "Give it a week."

He looked at the sky.

The sky was blue and uncomplicated.

He thought about Arjun's hand on the quad in the morning light.

"Okay," he said.

He found he meant it.

He found he meant it.

Chapter 38 — The First Real Touch

It happened on Sunday evening.

Not planned. Not set up. The way real moments always arrived — through the gap in ordinary time, while something else was happening.

They were in Kiran's room — Suresh reliably absent, the weekend stretching into its last hours before Monday lectures. They'd been reading, both of them, the comfortable parallel that had existed for months but had a different quality now. The same silence, the same ease, but warmer. Like the thermostat of it had been adjusted upward.

Kiran had been on his bed. Arjun had started on the bed too — book propped on his knees, the usual position — but had gradually, over the course of an hour, migrated. First lying back against the headboard. Then sliding slightly sideways. Then, without either of them marking the exact moment it happened, ending up against Kiran's side — shoulder against shoulder, arm against arm, the warmth of him a continuous presence down Kiran's left side.

Kiran had turned a page. The migration had continued.

Arjun's head had dropped to his shoulder again — the same as the roof, the same as midnight, except this was the afternoon, the daylight yellow through the window, nothing to hide anything.

Kiran had adjusted slightly — an accommodation, making the shoulder more available, the way you did when someone leaned into you and you wanted them to be comfortable.

Arjun made a quiet sound. Not words. Just: acknowledgment. Comfort.

They read.

Or tried to read.

Kiran had not retained anything from the past twenty minutes. He was very aware of the weight of Arjun against him, the specific warmth of his arm through the thin cotton of his t-shirt, the slow even sound of his breathing — all of it familiar from months of the roof and the library and the study sessions, but different now. The same notes in a different key.

- * -

At some point Arjun's book lowered.

He wasn't reading either.

Kiran lowered his.

They were still for a moment. The room. The afternoon. The sound of the campus outside going about its Sunday business.

Arjun turned his head — slightly, just enough — and pressed his lips to Kiran's shoulder.

Through the fabric. Brief. Barely there.

Not a kiss exactly. Something between a kiss and a rest. A thing that had no good English word for it — the pressing of one person's face to another because contact felt necessary, because proximity had become insufficient.

Kiran felt it the way he felt everything Arjun did — fully, specifically, in the load-bearing parts.

He turned his head.

His cheek rested against the top of Arjun's head.

His arm — the left one, between them — moved.

He put it around Arjun's shoulders.

Properly. Deliberately. His arm around him, pulling him slightly closer, and Arjun shifted with it — adjusted his whole body into the new arrangement, turning slightly so he was more fully against Kiran's side, one hand coming to rest against Kiran's chest. Open palm. Still.

Kiran felt the warmth of that hand through his t-shirt.

He felt the rise and fall of Arjun's breathing.

He felt the specific weight of him — a real physical weight, a person, this person, here.

Here, Arjun had said. **I'm going to be here.**

They stayed like that.

The afternoon light shifted. The shadows in the room moved. Somewhere below, someone called someone else's name. The ceiling fan turned at its medium speed.

Kiran had a thought, somewhere in the middle of all that stillness:

This is the thing. This specific thing right here. This is what I've been managing and rationing and keeping at a distance for nine months.

This.

He tightened his arm slightly around Arjun's shoulders.

Arjun's hand pressed flat against his chest — just for a moment, just a small increase in pressure. Like: **I know. I'm here. I'm not going anywhere.**

Neither of them spoke.

There was nothing that needed to be said.

Chapter 39 — What They Are (No Label, But Everything)

Monday arrived with lectures and the last stretch of semester and the ordinary machinery of college life resuming as if nothing had changed.

Everything had changed.

Not visibly — they were not different in public, not dramatically. They walked to the canteen, sat at the usual table, talked to Suresh and Dilip and Priya, did the things they had always done. But the texture of them had shifted in the specific way of things that have been named. The silences between them were the same silences. The proximity was the same proximity. But both of these things meant something different now than they had on Friday.

Arjun still showed up at seven. He still sat in his spot on the bed. He still occupied the adjacent library chair, still found Kiran's foot under the table, still appeared at the vending machine with the orange cold drink.

But now, sometimes, he arrived and sat close enough that their arms were touching and didn't pretend it was incidental. Now, walking back from lecture, his hand found the back of Kiran's neck briefly — warm, easy, a contact that said **you** without requiring elaboration. Now, in the library, he looked up sometimes from his book and found Kiran already looking, and neither of them looked away.

They had not discussed what they were.

Kiran thought about this on Tuesday, sitting at his desk while Arjun napped on his bed — an afternoon habit that had become established without comment, Arjun apparently having decided that Kiran's room was an acceptable place to sleep off post-lunch heaviness. He thought about labels. What they required. Whether they were necessary.

It was real and chosen and clear between them in the specific way of things that didn't need external framework to exist.

They knew what this was. That was enough for now.

- * -

And then Arjun woke up.

He blinked at the ceiling. Turned his head toward Kiran. The particular expression of someone arriving back from sleep — slightly soft, slightly unguarded, the armor not yet on.

"Hi," he said.

"Hi," Kiran said.

Arjun reached out his hand. Not toward Kiran — just out, an open offer. Lazy, undemanding.

Kiran looked at it.

He got up from his desk. Crossed to the bed. Lay down beside Arjun — on top of the covers, shoulder to shoulder, both of them looking at the ceiling.

Arjun's hand found his.

They looked at the ceiling fan turning.

"What are we doing on Saturday," Arjun said. After-nap voice. Slightly rough.

"The last exam is Friday."

"I know. Saturday after."

Kiran thought about it. "Anything you want."

Arjun was quiet for a moment. His thumb moving across Kiran's knuckles — the slow deliberate stroke that had started on the rooftop weeks ago and had become, apparently, a habit.

"That beach you photographed," he said.

Kiran turned his head.

Arjun was looking at the ceiling. Not at Kiran. But the slight colour at the edge of his ear said he knew Kiran was looking at him.

"Vizag?" Kiran said.

"Not Vizag. I just mean—" He paused. "A beach. I've never actually—" He stopped again. "Is there one near Hyderabad."

"No," Kiran said. "We're landlocked."

"Oh." A beat. "That's unfortunate."

"Yes."

Arjun was quiet.

"Tell me what it's like," he said. "The Vizag beach at 6 AM."

Kiran looked at the ceiling.

He described it. The way the light came off the water in the early morning — not gold yet, still that particular grey-blue of the hour before full sunrise. The temperature at that hour, cool enough for a light jacket. The sound of it, different from daytime — quieter, the waves having a different rhythm when there were no people to compete with. The specific smell. The birds.

Arjun listened with his eyes closed.

When Kiran stopped he was quiet for a moment.

"I want to see it," he said.

"You will," Kiran said. Simply. As fact.

Arjun turned his head.

They looked at each other on the bed in the afternoon light.

"Yeah," Arjun said. Soft. Something in his face that was — complete. Like everything had arrived.
"I will."

Kiran looked at him.

At this person who had found his library seat and eaten maggi in the corridor and pulled him into rain and held his wrist at a gate and said *I meant you* in the morning light.

"Arjun," he said.

"Hmm."

"I'm glad you sat in my seat."

A pause.

Then Arjun laughed — the real laugh, the unguarded one, the one that came from somewhere genuine. He turned onto his side, facing Kiran, the laugh settling into something warm.

"The library," he said. "You were so annoyed."

"I was not annoyed."

"You were very politely containing annoyance."

"That's different."

"It really isn't." He was still smiling. He reached over and tucked Kiran's hair back — two fingers, slow, the gesture from that first almost-moment months ago. But this time his hand didn't leave. It stayed against the side of Kiran's face, warm and still.

Kiran looked at him.

"I'm glad too," Arjun said quietly. Not the laugh anymore. Something beneath it. "I'm very glad."

Kiran covered Arjun's hand with his own.

Held it there.

Against his face. Warm.

The fan turned. The afternoon continued.

Neither of them moved.

Chapter 40 — The First Kiss

Friday. Last exam done.

The relief of it swept through the campus in the particular way it always did — not quietly, not with restraint. Music from open windows by 4 PM. Someone had produced a speaker somewhere. The canteen was louder than usual, the evening energy of a pressure released.

Kiran walked out of the exam hall into the late afternoon light and found Arjun leaning against the wall outside — not unusual, they'd planned this, meet here after — but the way he was standing, arms folded loosely, face turned up to the sky, was so entirely comfortable that Kiran stopped walking for a moment just to look at him.

The way he stood in light. The way he occupied space.

The way he looked up when Kiran stopped, found him immediately, and the corner of his mouth moved.

There he is, said something in Kiran's chest. The way it always said this. The way it had been saying this since October.

"How was it," Arjun said.

"Fine," Kiran said.

"Fine like fine or fine like—"

"Fine like fine."

Arjun pushed off the wall. He fell into step beside Kiran — matching his pace, the way he always did now. "Mine was—" He made a gesture. "There's a question I'm not sure about."

"The heat transfer one."

"How did you know."

"You mentioned it was unclear in your notes on Tuesday."

Arjun looked at him. "You remember that."

"I remember most things you tell me."

A pause. Arjun's arm pressed briefly against his as they walked.

"Of course you do," he said. Something warm in his voice. Something that was not quite all the way to the surface yet.

- * -

They walked back. The campus in its end-of-semester mode — people lounging on the grass, music

carrying, the general exhale of a week of exams completed. They went to the canteen, had tea with Suresh and Dilip and Priya, sat in the usual seats and talked about nothing important the way you talked about nothing after exams because the brain needed recovery time.

Priya caught Kiran's eye once across the table.

He looked back steadily.

She looked at her chai with the particular satisfaction of someone who had been right about something for a long time.

- * -

By eight the group had dispersed — Suresh to phone his girlfriend, Dilip to sleep, Priya to call her parents. And it was just the two of them again, the way it usually ended.

"Roof?" Arjun said.

"Yes."

They went up.

The Hyderabad evening was warm but not brutal — the semester-end May evening that had a softness to it, the air moving. The city below was lit and busy. Their spot on the parapet wall. Their silence settling around them like something familiar and known.

Kiran sat. Arjun sat. Shoulders touching.

Kiran thought: *this is the last time we'll be on this roof before break. Two weeks in Vizag. Two weeks in Delhi. Different cities, messages, the distance.*

He thought: *it's different this time.*

It was different. Last December he'd gone home not knowing, carrying something unnamed. This time he knew what he was going home with and coming back to.

"Hey," Arjun said.

"Hmm."

"Come here."

Kiran looked at him.

Arjun had turned slightly toward him — angled, open, one hand resting on the parapet between them with the deliberate quality of an invitation. He was looking at Kiran with the expression that had been developing in him over months — the fully arrived version, nothing still assembling, nothing held back.

Kiran turned toward him.

They were facing each other on the parapet wall, knees almost touching. The city behind Arjun. The warm evening air.

Arjun's hand came up to Kiran's face.

Not the way it had on the failed night — careful, tentative, asking. This was — settled.

His palm against Kiran's jaw, warm and certain, his thumb near the corner of his mouth.

Kiran looked at him.

"Last time," Arjun said quietly, "we were interrupted."

"Yes," Kiran said.

"There's no one up here."

Kiran looked around. He was right. The roof was empty — just the two of them and the city and the warm May evening.

"No," Kiran said. "There isn't."

Arjun looked at him. His thumb moved — the smallest motion, tracing the line from the corner of Kiran's mouth upward, slow and deliberate, mapping.

"Okay," Arjun said softly. Not a question.

"Yes," Kiran said. "Okay."

Arjun moved.

Slow. The way he always moved when it mattered — not the impulsive instinct-driven Arjun, but this version, the careful version, the version that understood the value of what it was handling.

He closed the distance.

His lips against Kiran's.

Soft. Warm. Present.

Not a brush, not a question — something that arrived and stayed. His hand still against Kiran's jaw, tilting slightly, adjusting the angle with the same quiet attention he gave to things he wanted to get right. His other hand finding the front of Kiran's shirt, fingers curling loosely into the fabric — not pulling, just holding. An anchor.

Kiran kissed him back.

He brought his hand up — the one that had been in his lap, uncertain — and placed it against Arjun's chest. Felt the steady warmth of him through the cotton. The rise of his ribs. The heartbeat, faster than his breathing suggested.

Fast.

Arjun's heart was beating fast.

That detail — more than anything, more than the warmth or the proximity or the years it had taken to arrive here — that detail undid Kiran completely.

*Arjun, whose heartbeat right now said: *this matters. I am not unaffected. I am here completely.**

He pressed his palm flat against his chest.

Arjun made a sound against his mouth — small, involuntary, the sound of someone feeling something they hadn't fully prepared for.

They pulled back by a centimetre.

Eyes opening.

Looking at each other in the close warm distance.

Arjun's thumb was still at the corner of Kiran's mouth. Kiran's hand was still on his chest.

"Hi," Arjun said. Barely above a whisper. Slightly undone. The smile trying to come through.

"Hi," Kiran said.

The smile came fully.

And then Arjun laughed — soft, real, the specifically delighted laugh of someone who has arrived somewhere they'd been trying to get to for a long time and found it better than expected.

Kiran felt the laugh against his forehead — Arjun had dropped his head forward, pressing it lightly to Kiran's — and felt something in himself that was so complete, so uncomplicated, so entirely without the management and rationing and careful distance of the past nine months that he didn't have a word for it.

Happy.

The word was happy.

He was just — happy.

"Took us long enough," Arjun said. Into his forehead. Still slightly laughing.

"Took **you** long enough," Kiran said.

Arjun pulled back enough to look at him. "That's fair," he said. "That's completely fair." His hand moved from Kiran's jaw to the back of his neck — warm, loose, staying. "I'll make it up to you."

"Nine months," Kiran said.

"However long it takes," Arjun said. Simply. Completely meaning it.

Kiran looked at him.

At his face in the evening light — the smile, the warmth, the specific aliveness of him when he was feeling something real. At the hand on the back of his neck. At the city behind him, the same city that had been there through all of it — the rooftop in December and the hand on the parapet and the interrupted almost and the 1 AM dark.

I meant you, Arjun had said.

I'm going to be here, Arjun had said.

He was.

Here. On this rooftop. In this evening. With his hand warm on the back of Kiran's neck and his heartbeat still slightly fast and the smile that was only ever really this real for Kiran.

Kiran moved the small distance back to him.

Kissed him again — softer this time, unhurried, both of them more settled in it now, the first one having made it real and this one making it easy.

Arjun's hand tightened slightly on the back of his neck.

The city hummed below them.

The evening continued.

Neither of them was in any hurry.